

## Indian Traditions, Culture and Society

- India is a diverse country with a rich and varied heritage of languages, religions, arts, cuisines, philosophies, and customs.
- India has been influenced by various cultures and civilizations throughout its history, such as the Indus Valley Civilization, the Vedic period, the Mauryan Empire, the Gupta Empire, the Islamic invasions, the Mughal Empire, the British colonial rule, and the modern independence movement.
- India is also home to many indigenous and tribal communities, each with their own distinct traditions and practices.
- Some of the salient features of Indian culture and society are:
  - Arts and Language: India has a vibrant and diverse literary and artistic tradition, dating back to the ancient Sanskrit language and literature, which is considered one of the oldest and most influential in the world. India has also produced many renowned poets, writers, philosophers, musicians, painters, sculptors, and architects, who have contributed to the global cultural heritage. India has 22 official languages and hundreds of regional and local languages and dialects, reflecting the linguistic diversity of the country.
  - Philosophy and Religion: India is the birthplace of four major world religions: Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism. India also has a significant population of Muslims, Christians, Zoroastrians, Jews, and other faiths, making it a secular and pluralistic society. India has also developed various schools of thought and systems of ethics, such as Vedanta, Yoga, Sankhya, Nyaya, Mimamsa, and Advaita, which have influenced the worldviews and lifestyles of many Indians.
  - Food and Drink: India has a rich and varied culinary tradition, influenced by the geography, climate, history, and culture of the different regions and communities. Indian cuisine is known for its use of spices, herbs, grains, legumes, vegetables, fruits, dairy products, and meats, as well as its diversity of dishes, such as curries, biryanis, dosas, idlis, samosas, chaats, sweets, and snacks. India also has a variety of beverages, such as tea, coffee, lassi, sherbet, and alcoholic drinks, such as toddy, feni, and arrack.
  - Society and Culture: India has a complex and hierarchical social structure, based on the concepts of caste, class, gender, religion, and region. India has also witnessed many social reforms and movements, such as the abolition of sati, the emancipation of women, the eradication of untouchability, and the promotion of education and human rights. India has a vibrant and colorful culture, marked by festivals, rituals, ceremonies, dances, music, costumes, and symbols, which celebrate the diversity and unity of the country.

## **Module 1- Society State and Polity in India**

- This module aims to provide an overview of the historical and contemporary aspects of the society, state and polity in India.
- Society refers to the network of social relationships, institutions, norms and values that shape the collective life of a group of people.
- State refers to the political organization that exercises sovereign authority over a defined territory and population.
- Polity refers to the system of governance, laws, policies and institutions that regulate the state and society.
- Some of the topics covered in this module are:
  - The ancient and medieval origins of Indian civil polity and its distinctive features, such as the concept of dharma, the role of kingship, the diversity of social groups and the emergence of republics and empires .
  - The colonial and post-colonial transformations of Indian society and state, such as the impact of British rule, the nationalist movement, the partition, the constitution, the federal system, the democratic institutions and the social movements .
  - The contemporary challenges and opportunities facing Indian society and state, such as the economic development, the social inequality, the cultural diversity, the regional integration, the international relations and the environmental issues .
- The module aims to develop the students' critical and analytical skills, as well as their awareness and appreciation of the complexity and richness of Indian society and state.

### **State in Ancient India**

- The state in ancient India was a social organization with political power that ensured peace, order and happiness.
- The origin of the state in ancient India is not clear, but there are three main theories: social contract theory, divine origin theory and organic theory.
- Social contract theory: This theory suggests that the state was formed by a voluntary agreement among the people to surrender some of their rights and freedoms to a ruler or a group of rulers in exchange for protection and welfare.
- Divine origin theory: This theory claims that the state was established by God or gods, who chose a king or a dynasty to rule over the people. The king was considered as the representative of God or gods on earth and had absolute authority and legitimacy.

- **Organic theory:** This theory views the state as a natural and inevitable outcome of the growth and development of human society. The state was seen as a living organism that evolved from the family, clan, tribe and village to a larger and more complex political entity.
- The types of states in ancient India were mainly monarchy, republic and oligarchy.
- **Monarchy:** This was the most common and prevalent type of state in ancient India. The king was the source of all power and authority and was assisted by ministers and provincial governors. The king was also the supreme judge, lawgiver and commander-in-chief of the army.
- **Republic:** This was a type of state where the people or their representatives had a say in the governance and administration of the state. The republics were usually formed by clans or tribes that had a common ancestry and culture. The republics had a council of elders or an assembly of citizens that elected or appointed the chief executive and other officials.
- **Oligarchy:** This was a type of state where a few powerful individuals or groups controlled the state and its resources. The oligarchs were usually wealthy landowners, merchants or military leaders who had influence and authority over the people. The oligarchs often competed or cooperated with each other for power and wealth.
- The earliest known state in ancient India was the Indus Valley Civilization, also known as the Harappan Civilization, that flourished from 3300 to 1300 BCE. It was a highly advanced and urbanized civilization that had a centralized administration, standardized weights and measures, seal carving, metallurgy, trade and agriculture.
- The later states in ancient India were influenced by the Vedic culture, which emerged around 1500 BCE. The Vedic texts, such as the Vedas, the Upanishads and the Mahabharata, contain references to various kingdoms, dynasties and empires that ruled over different regions of India. Some of the prominent states in ancient India were the Magadha Empire, the Mauryan Empire, the Gupta Empire, the Kushan Empire and the Chola Empire.

### Theories of origin of State in India

The origin of state in India is a subject of debate among scholars of political science and history. There are different theories that attempt to explain how the state emerged and evolved in ancient India. Some of the prominent theories are:

- **Social Contract Theory:** This theory holds that the state was formed by a voluntary agreement among individuals who gave up some of their natural rights and freedoms in exchange for security and order. The state was seen as a human creation that served the common good of the people. This theory is found in some ancient texts such as the Mahabharata, the Arthashastra and the Manusmriti .

- **Divine Origin Theory:** This theory asserts that the state was established by the will of God or gods who chose a king or a dynasty to rule over the people. The king was considered as the representative of God or gods on earth and had a sacred duty to uphold the divine law and order. The state was seen as a divine institution that derived its legitimacy from the religious authority of the king. This theory is found in some ancient texts such as the Vedas, the Ramayana and the Puranas .
- **Organic Theory:** This theory suggests that the state was a natural and inevitable outcome of the social and economic development of human society. The state was seen as a living organism that grew and changed according to the needs and aspirations of the people. The state was a product of the historical and cultural evolution of the people and reflected their collective identity and values. This theory is found in some ancient texts such as the Upanishads, the Dharmashastras and the Buddhist scriptures .

These theories are not mutually exclusive and may have influenced each other in different ways. They also have some common elements such as the recognition of the importance of law and order, the role of the king and the people, and the ethical and moral dimensions of the state. The theories of origin of state in India provide a rich and diverse perspective on the nature and function of the state in ancient India.

### **Evolutionary Theory of origin of State**

- The Evolutionary Theory of origin of State is the theory that explains the state as the product of historical and social evolution over a long period of time .
- According to this theory, the state is not a sudden or artificial creation, but a natural and gradual development of human society from simple to complex forms of organization .
- The Evolutionary Theory traces the origin of the state from the primitive stages of human society, such as the family, the clan, the tribe, the village, the city, and the nation, and shows how the state emerged as a result of various factors, such as population growth, economic needs, social differentiation, warfare, religion, and culture .
- The Evolutionary Theory is regarded as the most scientific and convincing theory of origin of the state, as it is based on historical evidence and anthropological research, and it accounts for the diversity and complexity of the state in different times and places .
- The Evolutionary Theory also helps to understand the functions and purposes of the state, as it shows the state to be a response to the changing needs and challenges of human society, and a means of achieving social order, justice, and progress .

### **Force Theory of Origin of State**

- The force theory of origin of state is a theory that proposes that the state emerged from the use of force by one person or a small group of people over a larger population in a certain territory .
- According to this theory, the state is a result of war, conquest, or domination by the strong over the weak .
- The force theory implies that the state is based on coercion, violence, and power, and that the people have no say in the formation or governance of the state.
- Some examples of states that are said to have originated from the force theory are the ancient empires of Egypt, Babylon, Assyria, Persia, Greece, Rome, and China, as well as some modern states such as Nazi Germany, Soviet Union, and North Korea .
- The force theory has been criticized for being too simplistic, unrealistic, and unethical, as it ignores the role of consent, cooperation, and social contract in the origin and development of the state .

### Mystical Theory of Origin of State

- The mystical theory of origin of state is also known as the **divine origin theory** or the **theory of divine right of kings** .
- The exponents of this theory believe that the state did not come into being by any effort of man, but by the **will of God** .
- According to this theory, the **king** or the **ruler** of the state is the **representative** or the **vicegerent** of God on earth, and therefore has **absolute authority** and **infallibility** .
- The subjects of the state have the **duty** to **obey** and **revere** the king as the **divine** or the **chosen** one .
- The proponents of this theory include **ancient** and **medieval** thinkers and rulers, such as **Plato, Aristotle, Augustine, Aquinas, James I, Louis XIV**, etc .
- The main **arguments** in favor of this theory are:
  - It provides a **simple** and **clear** explanation of the origin and nature of the state.
  - It gives a **strong** and **stable** basis for the **legitimacy** and **continuity** of the state.
  - It fosters a **sense** of **loyalty**, **devotion**, and **morality** among the people.
  - It prevents **rebellion**, **anarchy**, and **chaos** by discouraging any **challenge** or **criticism** of the ruler.
- The main **criticisms** of this theory are:
  - It is based on **faith** and **superstition**, not on **reason** and **evidence** .

- It contradicts the **historical** and **empirical** facts of the origin and development of the state .
- It ignores the **diversity** and **complexity** of the political and social phenomena .
- It justifies the **tyranny**, **oppression**, and **exploitation** of the ruler over the people .
- It violates the **rights**, **freedom**, and **dignity** of the people .
- The mystical theory of origin of state is now **rejected** and **discredited** by most modern political thinkers and scholars, who prefer more **scientific** and **rational** theories, such as the **historical** or **evolutionary** theory .

### Contract Theory of Origin of State

- The contract theory of origin of state is a theory that explains how the state or the society came into being by a voluntary agreement or contract among individuals or groups of people.
- The contract theory assumes that there was a state of nature before the state, where people lived in natural conditions without any law or authority, and faced problems of insecurity, violence, and disorder.
- The contract theory also assumes that people are rational and self-interested, and that they have natural rights to life, liberty, and property, which they want to protect and enjoy.
- The contract theory proposes that people decided to leave the state of nature and enter into a social contract, where they agreed to give up some of their natural rights and obey a common authority or government, in exchange for protection, peace, and order.
- The contract theory has different versions and variations, depending on the views of different thinkers and philosophers, such as Thomas Hobbes, John Locke, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and Immanuel Kant.
- The contract theory has been influential and controversial in the history of political thought, as it provides a basis for the legitimacy, authority, and obligation of the state and the government, as well as the rights and duties of the citizens.

### Stages of State Formation in Ancient India

- State formation in ancient India is the process of emergence and consolidation of political entities that exercised authority and control over a territory and population.
- State formation is linked with the growth and spread of agriculture, trade, industry and urbanisation, which generated surplus and enabled the creation and appropriation of resources.
- The stages of state formation in ancient India can be broadly divided into four phases: the Vedic period, the Mahajanapada period, the Mauryan period and the post-Mauryan period.

### **The Vedic Period (c. 1500-600 BCE)**

- The Vedic period is the earliest phase of state formation in ancient India, marked by the arrival and settlement of the Indo-Aryan speakers in the north-western part of the subcontinent.
- The Vedic society was organised into tribes (jana) and clans (vish), which were led by chiefs (raja) and elders (sabha and samiti). The tribes were often engaged in conflicts and alliances with each other over land, cattle and resources.
- The Vedic state was based on kinship, ritual and sacrifice, and had a limited territorial scope and administrative apparatus. The raja was mainly a war leader and a patron of priests, and did not have absolute authority or a permanent bureaucracy.
- The Vedic state gradually evolved into a more complex and hierarchical polity, with the emergence of larger territorial units (janapada), the differentiation of social classes (varna), the codification of laws (dharma) and the expansion of trade and urbanisation.

### **The Mahajanapada Period (c. 600-300 BCE)**

- The Mahajanapada period is the second phase of state formation in ancient India, marked by the formation and consolidation of sixteen major kingdoms or republics (mahajanapada) in northern and central India.
- The Mahajanapada states were more centralised and organised than the Vedic states, with a well-defined territory, a standing army, a regular taxation system, a coinage system and a network of roads and trade routes.
- The Mahajanapada states were also more diverse and pluralistic than the Vedic states, with different forms of governance (monarchy or oligarchy), different religious traditions (Vedic, Jain, Buddhist or Ajivika) and different cultural and linguistic identities.
- The Mahajanapada states were often in competition and conflict with each other for supremacy and resources, which led to the rise of powerful and ambitious rulers, such as Bimbisara of Magadha, Ajatashatru of Magadha, Prasenjit of Kosala and Udayana of Vatsa.

### **The Mauryan Period (c. 300-185 BCE)**

- The Mauryan period is the third phase of state formation in ancient India, marked by the establishment and expansion of the first pan-Indian empire by Chandragupta Maurya and his successors, Ashoka and Bindusara.
- The Mauryan empire was the largest and most powerful state in ancient India, extending from Afghanistan to Bengal and from Kashmir to Karnataka. It had a centralised and bureaucratic administration, a professional and disciplined army, a uniform and standardised coinage system, a well-developed infrastructure and a cosmopolitan culture.
- The Mauryan empire was also the most diverse and tolerant state in ancient India, with a policy of religious and cultural pluralism, as exemplified

by Ashoka's edicts, which promoted dhamma (moral law), ahimsa (non-violence), welfare (sukha) and harmony (samavaya) among all beings.

- The Mauryan empire declined and disintegrated after the death of Ashoka, due to internal rebellions, external invasions and economic and political instability.

### The Post-Mauryan Period (c. 185 BCE-300 CE)

- The post-Mauryan period is the fourth and final phase of state formation in ancient India, marked by the emergence and coexistence of multiple regional and local states in different parts of the subcontinent.
- The post-Mauryan states were smaller and weaker than the Mauryan empire, but more diverse and dynamic, with different political, economic, social and cultural features. Some of the prominent post-Mauryan states were the Sunga, Kanva, Satavahana, Kushana, Shaka, Indo-Greek, Indo-Parthian, Indo-Scythian and Gupta dynasties.
- The post-Mauryan states

### Kingship in states in Ancient India

- Kingship in ancient India was a **sovereignty** over a territory by a **King** who functioned as its **protector**, a role which involved both **secular and religious power**.
- Ancient Indians believed that the Kingship arose out of **military requirement**. The Vedic literature has some speculations about the origin of kingship. A king must be a capable general whose leadership is recognized by all.
- There were three main theories of origin of state in ancient India: **divine origin theory**, **social contract theory**, and **organic theory**.
  - Divine origin theory: This theory of origin of kingship as well as the state was not widely acclaimed in the ancient Indian polity. The king, according to this theory, was a subordinate to law, which was made by the society and not him.
  - Social contract theory: This theory of origin of kingship as well as the state was more popular in the ancient Indian polity. The king, according to this theory, was a representative of the people who had voluntarily surrendered their rights and powers to him for the sake of security and order.
  - Organic theory: This theory of origin of kingship as well as the state was based on the analogy of the human body. The king, according to this theory, was the head of the state, which was composed of various organs and limbs, each performing a specific function for the welfare of the whole.
- The ideology and symbolism of kingship have played an important role in Hinduism throughout its history, an influence that continues into the present day. The two great epic texts, the **Mahābhārata** and



**Rāmāyaṇa**, are narratives of kingship, and the tensions and ambiguities inherent to the role of the king are fundamental to their plots and themes.

- The Brahmanic theory of kingship was the most influential and dominant theory of kingship in ancient India. It was based on the concept of **dharma**, or the cosmic order, which the king had to uphold and protect. The king was considered to be the **incarnation of a god**, or the **deputy of a god**, who had the divine sanction and authority to rule.

### Council of Ministers in Ancient India

- The council of ministers was a body of advisers who assisted the king in the administration of the state.
- The council of ministers was known by different names, such as Mantri-parīṣad, Mantri-maṇḍala, or Mantri-gaṇa .
- The council of ministers was composed of various types of ministers, such as the Prime Minister (Mantrimukhya or Mahāmantri), the Chief Justice (Prādhyāpaka or Prādhyakṣa), the Treasurer (Sannidhāta or Kośādhyakṣa), the Commander-in-Chief (Senāpati or Senānī), the Foreign Minister (Dūta or Sandhivigrahika), and others.
- The council of ministers was selected by the king based on their qualifications, character, and loyalty. The ministers were expected to be well-versed in the scriptures, law, politics, economics, and military affairs. They were also expected to be honest, brave, intelligent, and devoted to the king and the welfare of the people .
- The council of ministers had various functions, such as advising the king on important matters, executing the king's orders, supervising the administration of various departments, maintaining law and order, collecting revenue, conducting diplomacy, and leading the army .
- The council of ministers was not a mere rubber stamp of the king, but had some degree of autonomy and influence. The ministers could express their opinions freely and frankly, and sometimes even oppose the king's views. The king was expected to consult the council of ministers before taking any major decision, and respect their consensus. The council of ministers could also act as a check and balance on the king's power, and prevent him from becoming tyrannical or negligent .

### Administration in Ancient India

- Administration in ancient India refers to the structures, procedures and behaviors that the ruling dynasties or emperors used to govern their respective territories and people.
- Administration in ancient India can be traced back to the Indus Valley civilization, which had a systematic and well-organized government in the cities of Mohenjodaro and Harappa.
- Administration in ancient India varied according to the different periods, regions and cultures, but some common features can be identified, such

as:

- The king was the head of administration and the supreme authority in matters of law, justice, religion, defense and taxation. The king was assisted by ministers, councillors, generals and officials who advised him and carried out his orders .
- The state was divided into provinces and districts for administrative convenience and local governance. The provinces were governed by governors or viceroys appointed by the king, while the districts were headed by local chiefs or officers who collected revenue and maintained law and order.
- The administration was based on the principles of dharma (duty, righteousness, morality) and artha (wealth, power, policy). The king and his officials were expected to uphold dharma and protect the interests of the people, while also pursuing artha and expanding the territory and resources of the state.
- The administration was influenced by the religious and philosophical traditions of ancient India, such as Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and others. The king was often regarded as a representative of God or a divine incarnation, and was expected to perform rituals and sacrifices to please the deities and ensure the welfare of the state.
- The administration was also influenced by the social and economic conditions of ancient India, such as the caste system, the varna system, the guild system, the village system and others. The administration had to balance the rights and duties of the different classes and groups of society, and also promote trade, agriculture, industry and education.

### **Political Ideals in Ancient India and their relevance in modern times**

- Ancient India had a rich tradition of political thought and practice that spanned from the Vedic period to the medieval period.
- Some of the political ideals that emerged from ancient India are:
  - Democracy: The Rig Veda, the oldest of the four Vedas, depicts a form of democracy based on the collective will of the people, called Samjnana. The Vedic society was divided into four varnas or classes, each with its own duties and rights. The people participated in the assemblies called sabha and samiti, where they discussed and decided on various matters of common interest. The king was elected by the people and was accountable to them. He was also guided by a council of elders and priests. Democracy in ancient India was not based on universal suffrage, but on the principle of consent and consensus.
  - Dharma: Dharma is a Sanskrit term that means duty, law, morality, justice, righteousness, or order. It is the basis of the Vedic ideals and the Indian political thought. Dharma regulates the conduct of the individual, the society, and the state. It is derived from the eternal

and universal laws of nature and the divine will. Dharma aims at the welfare of all beings and the harmony of the cosmos. The king was the upholder and protector of dharma. He had to follow the dharma himself and ensure that his subjects also followed it. He had to rule with compassion, wisdom, and impartiality. Dharma also implies the respect for diversity and pluralism, as it recognizes the different paths and goals of human life .

- Artha: Artha is another Sanskrit term that means wealth, material prosperity, power, or polity. It is one of the four goals of human life, along with dharma, kama (pleasure), and moksha (liberation). Artha is the subject matter of the Arthashastra, the ancient treatise on statecraft and economics, attributed to Kautilya or Chanakya, the adviser of the Mauryan emperor Chandragupta. Artha deals with the practical aspects of governance, such as administration, taxation, diplomacy, war, law, and trade. Artha also implies the pursuit of self-interest and rationality, as well as the balance between the ends and the means.
- Ahimsa: Ahimsa is another Sanskrit term that means non-violence, non-injury, or non-harming. It is one of the cardinal virtues of the Indian religions, such as Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism. Ahimsa implies the respect for all forms of life and the avoidance of harm or injury to any living being, either by thought, word, or deed. Ahimsa also implies the promotion of peace, harmony, and compassion in the world. Ahimsa was the basis of the non-violent resistance movements led by Mahatma Gandhi and other freedom fighters against the British colonial rule in India.
- The relevance of these political ideals in modern times are:
  - Democracy: Democracy is widely accepted as the best form of government in the modern world, as it ensures the participation, representation, and accountability of the people. Democracy also fosters the values of freedom, equality, and justice in the society. Democracy in modern India is inspired by the ancient Vedic democracy, as well as the western democratic traditions. The Constitution of India, adopted in 1950, establishes India as a sovereign, socialist, secular, and democratic republic. It grants universal adult suffrage, fundamental rights, and federalism to the citizens of India. It also provides for a parliamentary system of government, with a bicameral legislature, an executive headed by the prime minister, and an independent judiciary.
  - Dharma: Dharma is still relevant in modern times, as it provides a moral and ethical framework for the individual, the society, and the state. Dharma also helps in the preservation and promotion of the cultural and spiritual heritage of India. Dharma also reflects the diversity and pluralism of India, as it accommodates the different religions, languages, regions, and communities of the country. Dharma

also guides the foreign policy of India, as it advocates for the principles of non-alignment, peaceful coexistence, and cooperation among the nations .

- Artha: Artha is also relevant in modern times, as it deals with the economic and political aspects of governance. Ar

### Conditions of the Welfare of Societies in Ancient India

- The concept of social welfare in ancient India was based on the idea of **duty** as opposed to **rights** . The duty of an individual was determined by his or her **dharma**, which was the moral and ethical code of conduct for different classes and stages of life .
- The dharma of the king or the ruler was called **rajadharma**, which included the responsibility of ensuring the welfare of the people, maintaining justice and order, protecting the weak and the oppressed, and promoting the common good . The king was considered as the representative of God on earth and was expected to rule with benevolence and wisdom .
- The welfare of the society was also dependent on the cooperation and harmony among the four **varnas** or social classes: the Brahmins (priests and scholars), the Kshatriyas (warriors and rulers), the Vaishyas (merchants and farmers), and the Shudras (servants and laborers). Each varna had its own dharma and privileges, and was expected to perform its duties faithfully and respectfully.
- The society was also divided into four **ashramas** or stages of life: the Brahmacharya (student), the Grihastha (householder), the Vanaprastha (retired), and the Sannyasa (renunciant). Each ashrama had its own dharma and obligations, and was meant to help the individual attain spiritual and moral growth.
- The welfare of the individual and the society was also influenced by the performance of various **sanskaras** or sacraments, which were rites of passage that marked the important events and transitions in one's life, such as birth, initiation, marriage, death, etc.. These sanskaras were meant to purify, sanctify, and elevate the individual and the society.
- The welfare of the society was also enhanced by the role of the **family**, which was the basic unit of social organization and the source of moral and emotional support. The family was patriarchal and joint, and the elders were respected and obeyed. The family was also responsible for the education and upbringing of the children, and the transmission of the cultural and religious values.
- The welfare of the society was also affected by the **marriage** system, which was considered as a sacred and lifelong bond between a man and a woman. The marriage was arranged by the parents or the elders, and the consent of the bride and the groom was not necessary. The marriage was also based on the compatibility of the varnas, the gotras (clans), and the horoscopes.
- The welfare of the society was also influenced by the **position of women**,

which varied according to the time period, the region, the class, and the religion. In general, women were subordinate to men and had limited rights and freedoms. However, some women also enjoyed high status and respect as queens, warriors, poets, teachers, etc.. Women were also expected to be loyal, virtuous, and devoted to their husbands and families.

- The welfare of the society was also reflected by the **dresses and ornaments** of the people, which indicated their class, status, occupation, and taste. The people wore simple and comfortable clothes made of cotton, silk, or wool, and adorned themselves with various kinds of jewelry made of gold, silver, pearls, gems, etc.. The dresses and ornaments also varied according to the seasons, the occasions, and the regions.
- The welfare of the society was also manifested by the **food habits** of the people, which were influenced by the climate, the geography, the religion, and the culture. The people ate a variety of cereals, pulses, fruits, vegetables, milk, honey, etc., and avoided meat, alcohol, and intoxicants. The food habits also differed according to the varnas, the ashramas, and the regions.
- The welfare of the society was also expressed by the **amusements and entertainments** of the people, which were sources of joy, relaxation, and education. The people enjoyed

### The Seven Limbs of the State in Ancient India

- The seven limbs of the state (saptanga) is a political concept given by Kautilya in his treatise Arthashastra, which deals with the art of governance and statecraft .
- The seven limbs are:
  - King (Svamin): The king is the supreme authority and the head of the state. He is responsible for the peace, justice and stability of the state. He is independent and has the power to appoint and dismiss his ministers and officials. He is also the commander-in-chief of the army and the protector of the people .
  - Amatya (Minister or Bureaucrat): The amatya is the second in command and the chief adviser of the king. He assists the king in administration, policy-making and diplomacy. He is selected on the basis of merit, loyalty and experience. He supervises the various departments and officials of the state .
  - Janapada (Territory or Population): The janapada is the third limb of the state and consists of the land and the people living in it. The land should be fertile, well-watered and rich in natural resources. The people should be loyal, obedient and prosperous. The king should protect the janapada from external and internal enemies and ensure its welfare .
  - Durga (Fort or Capital): The durga is the fourth limb of the state and refers to the fortified city or the capital of the state. It is the center of administration, commerce and culture. It should be well-built,

well-guarded and well-equipped. It should have strong walls, gates, towers and moats. It should also have ample provisions, weapons and manpower .

- Kosa (Treasure or Revenue): The kosa is the fifth limb of the state and refers to the financial resources and the income of the state. It is derived from various sources such as taxes, fines, tributes, trade, mines, etc. It should be sufficient, regular and increasing. It should be used for the maintenance of the state, the welfare of the people and the expansion of the territory .
- Danda (Coercive Authority or Army): The danda is the sixth limb of the state and refers to the military force and the law enforcement of the state. It is the instrument of the king to maintain order, justice and security. It consists of four branches: infantry, cavalry, chariots and elephants. It should be well-trained, well-equipped and well-disciplined. It should also be loyal, brave and patriotic .
- Mitra (Ally or Friend): The mitra is the seventh and the last limb of the state and refers to the friendly and supportive relations with other states. It is based on mutual trust, respect and benefit. It is achieved through diplomacy, treaties and alliances. It helps the state to counter the enemies, expand the territory and enhance the prestige .
- The seven limbs of the state are interdependent and interrelated. They should be balanced, harmonious and efficient. They should work together for the common good of the state. Kautilya considered the king as the most important limb, followed by the amatya, the janapada, the durga, the kosa, the danda and the mitra .

### Society in Ancient India

- The society in ancient India was based on the concept of **varna** and **ashrama**, which divided the people into four main classes and four stages of life respectively.
- The four classes or varnas were **Brahmins** (priests and scholars), **Kshatriyas** (warriors and rulers), **Vaishyas** (merchants and farmers), and **Shudras** (servants and laborers). There was also a fifth group of people who were outside the varna system, called the **Untouchables** or **Dalits**, who performed the most menial and polluting tasks .
- The four stages or ashramas of life were **Brahmacharya** (student), **Grihastha** (householder), **Vanaprastha** (retired), and **Sannyasa** (renunciant). Each stage had its own duties and responsibilities, and was meant to help the individual achieve spiritual and moral growth.
- The society in ancient India was also influenced by the various religions and philosophies that emerged in the region, such as **Hinduism**, **Buddhism**, **Jainism**, and **Sikhism**. These religions shaped the beliefs, values, rituals, and practices of the people, and also contributed to the development of art, literature, science, and culture .

- The society in ancient India was also marked by the rise and fall of several empires and kingdoms, such as the **Indus Valley Civilization**, the **Mauryan Empire**, the **Gupta Empire**, the **Mughal Empire**, and the **British Raj**. These political entities brought about changes in the social, economic, and cultural aspects of the society, and also interacted with other regions and peoples through trade, war, and diplomacy .

### Purusārtha in Society in Ancient India

- Purusārtha (Sanskrit: पुरुषार्थ) literally means “object of human pursuit” or “human goal”.
- It is a key concept in Hinduism, and refers to the four proper goals or aims of a human life. The four purusārthas are Dharma (righteousness, moral values), Artha (prosperity, economic values), Kama (pleasure, love, psychological values) and Moksha (liberation, spiritual values).
- The concept of purusārtha is a fundamental principle of social ethics in ancient India. It is meant to set an ideal objective and also to convey the right means to achieve them. The four purusārthas are not mutually exclusive, but rather interdependent and complementary. They are also flexible and adaptable to the individual’s stage of life, social class, and personal preference.
- The concept of purusārtha is also closely related to the concept of karma, which means action or deed. Karma is the law of cause and effect that governs the cycle of rebirth (samsara) in Hinduism. According to karma, every action has a consequence, either in this life or in the next. The purusārthas are the means to achieve the desired consequences and to avoid the undesired ones. By following the purusārthas, one can accumulate good karma and attain moksha, the ultimate goal of liberation from samsara.
- The concept of purusārtha also reflects the diversity and complexity of the ancient Indian society, which was divided into four classes (varnas) and four stages of life (ashramas). Each class and stage had its own duties and responsibilities, as well as its own scope and limitations. The purusārthas provided a framework for the individual to balance the different aspects of life and to fulfill the social and spiritual obligations.

### Varnāshrama System in Society in Ancient India

- Varnāshrama system is a term that refers to the division of Hindu society into four varnas (classes) and four ashramas (stages of life).
- The four varnas are Brahman (priests and teachers), Kshatriya (kings and warriors), Vaishya (traders and merchants), and Sudra (servants and laborers).
- The four ashramas are Brahmacharya (student), Grihastha (householder), Vanaprastha (forest dweller), and Sannyasa (renunciate).

- The varnāshrama system is based on the concept of dharma, which means duty, law, or morality. Each varna and ashrama has its own specific duties and obligations, according to the scriptures and the lawgivers.
- The varnāshrama system is meant to ensure the harmony and order of society, as well as the spiritual progress of the individual. It is also a way of organizing the social and economic activities of the people.
- The varnāshrama system is not rigid or fixed, but flexible and dynamic. It allows for mobility and change, depending on the circumstances and the qualifications of the person. It is not based on birth or caste, but on merit and character.
- The varnāshrama system is not a system of oppression or discrimination, but a system of cooperation and mutual respect. It recognizes the diversity and interdependence of the human society, and the need for balance and moderation in life.

### **Āshrama or the Stages of Life in Society in Ancient India**

- Āshrama (Sanskrit: आश्रम) is a system of stages of life discussed in Hindu texts of the ancient and medieval eras.
- The Āshrama system is one facet of the Dharma concept in Hinduism, which prescribes the duties and responsibilities of an individual according to his or her age, gender, occupation and social status .
- The four āshramas are:
  - Brahmacharya (student), marked by chastity, devotion, and obedience to one's teacher. This stage lasts until the age of 25, and involves learning the scriptures, the arts, the sciences, and the skills necessary for one's future profession.
  - Gṛhastha (householder), requiring marriage, the begetting of children, sustaining one's family and helping support priests and holy men, and fulfillment of duties toward gods and ancestors. This stage lasts until the age of 50, and involves performing the rituals, the sacrifices, the charity, and the social service prescribed by the scriptures.
  - Vanaprastha (forest walker/forest dweller), involving gradual withdrawal from worldly affairs, detachment from material possessions, and increased focus on spiritual pursuits. This stage lasts until the age of 75, and involves living in a forest hut or a hermitage, practicing meditation, penance, and self-discipline, and seeking the guidance of a guru or a sage.
  - Sannyasa (renunciate), involving complete renunciation of worldly life, attachment, and identity, and dedication to the quest for liberation (moksha) from the cycle of birth and death (samsara). This stage lasts until the end of one's life, and involves wandering as a mendicant, living on alms, studying the scriptures, and teaching the truth to those who seek it.
- The Āshrama system was meant to provide a framework for the spiritual and moral development of an individual, as well as for the social and



economic welfare of the society. It was also meant to reflect the natural stages of human life, and to harmonize the individual's goals with the cosmic order.

### **Marriage in Society in Ancient India**

- Marriage was a sacred institution that united two halves of life, man and woman, to form a complete and organic whole.
- Marriage was also a social contract that established kinship ties, rights and duties, and mutual support between the spouses and their families .
- Marriage was regulated by various laws and customs, such as caste, gotra, varna, and kula, that determined the eligibility and compatibility of the partners .
- Marriage was performed through various rituals and ceremonies, such as the kanyadan, the saptapadi, the homa, and the mangalsutra, that symbolized the sanctity and permanence of the bond .
- Marriage was classified into eight main types, based on the mode of acquisition of the bride and the consent of the parties involved. These were: Brahma, Daiva, Arsha, Prajapatya, Gandharva, Asura, Rakshasa, and Paisacha .
- Marriage was influenced by various factors, such as economic, political, religious, and cultural, that shaped the norms and expectations of the spouses and their roles and responsibilities in the family and society .

### **Understanding Gender as a Social Category in Society in Ancient India**

- Gender is a social construct that refers to the roles, expectations, and norms associated with being male or female in a given society.
- Gender roles vary across time and space, and are influenced by factors such as religion, culture, politics, and economics.
- In ancient India, gender roles were largely determined by the Vedic scriptures, which prescribed different duties and rights for men and women according to their varna (caste) and ashrama (stage of life).
- Generally, men were expected to perform the three main duties of a householder: studying the Vedas, performing sacrifices, and producing offspring. Women were expected to assist their husbands in these duties, and to be obedient, loyal, and chaste.
- Women were also expected to observe the four stages of life: brahmacharya (celibacy), grihastha (household), vanaprastha (retirement), and sannyasa (renunciation). However, women were not allowed to enter the last two stages, and had to remain as dependents of their husbands or sons.
- Women were denied access to formal education, public life, and religious authority. They were also subject to various restrictions and discriminations, such as sati (widow immolation), child marriage, dowry, and polygamy.

- However, there were some exceptions and variations in the status and role of women in ancient India, depending on the region, period, and source of information.
- Some sources indicate that women in ancient India enjoyed a high degree of respect and dignity, and participated in various fields of knowledge, arts, and culture. There were women rishis (sages), poets, philosophers, teachers, and rulers in ancient India, who were revered and celebrated for their achievements.
- Some sources also suggest that women had some degree of autonomy and choice in their personal and marital lives, and could exercise their rights to property, inheritance, divorce, and remarriage.
- Some sources also highlight the diversity and complexity of gender relations in ancient India, and the existence of alternative and non-normative forms of gender identity and expression, such as the third gender, transgender, and intersex people.

#### **The representation of Women in Historical traditions in Society in Ancient India**

- Women in ancient India had a complex and varied status depending on the time period, the region, the religion, and the caste they belonged to.
- During the Indus Valley Civilization (2500-1500 BCE), women were worshiped as mother goddesses and enjoyed equal honor and freedom as men. They could participate in war, gymnastics, public activities, decision-making, and education.
- During the Vedic period (1500-500 BCE), women also held an honored place in society and were respected as wives, mothers, and scholars. They could perform religious rituals, compose hymns, and study the Vedas. Some of the famous women sages of this period were Gargi, Maitreyi, Lopamudra, and Ghosha .
- During the later Vedic period (500-200 BCE), the status of women began to decline due to the rise of patriarchy, caste system, and Brahmanical orthodoxy. Women were gradually excluded from education, property rights, and public life. They were subjected to the authority of their fathers, husbands, and sons. They had to follow the norms of chastity, obedience, and loyalty. They were also expected to practice sati (self-immolation on the husband's funeral pyre) or widowhood .
- During the Mauryan period (321-185 BCE), the status of women improved slightly due to the influence of Buddhism and Jainism, which advocated non-violence, equality, and compassion. Women could join the monastic orders, preach the doctrines, and attain salvation. Some of the prominent women figures of this period were Chandragupta Maurya's chief queen Durdhara, Ashoka's daughter Sanghamitra, and the Buddhist nun Dham-mawati .
- During the Gupta period (320-550 CE), the status of women deteriorated further due to the revival of Hinduism and the codification of laws such as

the Manusmriti, which prescribed the ideal duties and behavior of women. Women were confined to the domestic sphere, denied education and independence, and subjected to various restrictions and regulations. They were also exploited and oppressed by the upper castes and classes. However, some women still excelled in the fields of literature, art, and science. Some of the notable women of this period were the poet Kalidasa's wife Malavika, the mathematician Lilavati, and the queen Prabhavatigupta .

- In conclusion, women in ancient India had a diverse and dynamic role in society, which changed according to the historical, cultural, and religious factors. They were not passive or homogeneous, but active and heterogeneous agents of change and continuity. They contributed to the development and enrichment of the Indian civilization in various ways.

### **Challenges faced by Women in Society in Ancient India**

- Women in ancient India had different roles and rights depending on the time period, the region, the religion, and the caste they belonged to. Generally, they faced more challenges and oppression as time went by and patriarchy became stronger.
- Some of the challenges faced by women in ancient India were:
  - Lack of autonomy, mobility, and social freedom. Women were expected to be dependent on their fathers, husbands, or sons for their livelihood, protection, and decision-making. They were confined to the domestic sphere and had limited access to education, property, and public life.
  - Child marriage and widowhood. Women were often married off at a very young age, sometimes even before puberty, to older men. They had no say in choosing their partners and had to bear children and serve their husbands. If their husbands died, they were either forced to commit sati (self-immolation on the funeral pyre of their husbands), or to live a life of misery and social ostracism as widows .
  - Sati, Pardha, and Devadasi systems. These were some of the abusive and oppressive practices that women had to endure in ancient India. Sati was the ritual of burning widows alive with their dead husbands, which was seen as a sign of loyalty and virtue. Pardha was the practice of veiling and secluding women from the outside world, which was seen as a sign of modesty and honor. Devadasi was the practice of dedicating young girls to temples as servants and prostitutes, which was seen as a sign of devotion and sacrifice .
  - Dasi, Niyog, and Polygamy. These were some of the other forms of exploitation and discrimination that women faced in ancient India. Dasi was the term for female slaves who were captured, bought, or sold by men. They had no rights and were subjected to sexual and physical abuse. Niyog was the practice of allowing a widow or a barren woman to have sexual relations with another man, usually a

relative of her husband, to produce a child. This was seen as a way of preserving the lineage and inheritance of the husband. Polygamy was the practice of allowing a man to have more than one wife, which was seen as a sign of wealth and power .

- Women in ancient India also had some positive aspects in their lives, such as the respect and reverence given to some goddesses, the role of some women as sages, teachers, poets, and rulers, and the influence of some religions and philosophies that advocated for women's rights and equality. However, these were exceptions rather than the norm, and the majority of women faced many challenges and hardships in their society .

#### Four-class Classification of Society in Ancient India

- The four-class classification of society in ancient India is also known as the **varna system** or the **caste system**.
- The word varna means **color** or **quality** in Sanskrit, and it was used to categorize people based on their **occupation, birth, and duty**.
- The varna system is derived from the **Vedas**, the ancient Hindu scriptures, which described four main social classes: **Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas**, and **Shudras** .
- The **Brahmins** were the **priests** and **scholars** who performed religious rituals, taught the Vedas, and advised the rulers. They were considered the highest and purest class in the society .
- The **Kshatriyas** were the **rulers, administrators**, and **warriors** who protected the society from external threats, maintained law and order, and enforced justice. They were the second highest class in the society .
- The **Vaishyas** were the **cattle herders, agriculturists, artisans**, and **merchants** who produced and traded goods and services. They were the third highest class in the society .
- The **Shudras** were the **laborers** and **service providers** who performed menial and unskilled tasks for the other classes. They were the lowest and most impure class in the society .
- The varna system was **rigid** and **hereditary**, meaning that people were born into a certain class and could not change it. The classes were also **hierarchical** and **exclusive**, meaning that people of different classes could not interact or intermarry with each other.
- The varna system was also influenced by the concept of **karma** and **re-birth**, which held that people's actions in their current life determined their status in their next life. Therefore, people had to follow their **dharma**, or their moral duty, according to their class, in order to achieve **moksha**, or liberation from the cycle of birth and death.
- The varna system was a dominant feature of the social structure of ancient India, and it influenced the political, economic, religious, and cultural aspects of the society. However, it also faced criticism and challenges from various movements and thinkers, such as Buddhism, Jainism, and the Bhakti movement, which advocated for equality and social justice.

### **Slavery in Society in Ancient India**

- Slavery was a universal social evil and had its origin even from the early period of history. In India, its origin is closely associated with the caste system.
- The early history of slavery in India is contested because it depends on the translations of terms such as *dasa* and *dasyu*, which could mean either enemies or servants.
- Greek writer Megasthenes, who visited India in the 4th century BCE, stated that slavery was banned in Indian society under the Mauryan Empire.
- However, slavery was practiced in various forms in ancient India, such as debt slavery, domestic slavery, military slavery, and temple slavery.
- Slavery system in India was very mild and most of the slaves were domestic slaves who were treated as members of the family. The Dharma Shastras of the 4th century BCE were in a protesting mood against slavery. Slave trade was prohibited in the Shastras.
- Slavery existed in ancient India, where it is recorded in the Sanskrit Laws of Manu of the 1st century BCE. The institution was little documented until the British colonials in the 19th century made it an object of study because of their desire to abolish it.
- Many Africans travelled to India as slaves and traders, but eventually settled down here to play an important role in India's history of kingdoms, conquests and wars. Some of them, like Malik Ambar and Malik Kafur, rose to become generals, governors, and rulers.

### **Module 2- Indian Literature, Culture, Tradition, and Practices**

- Indian literature is the literature produced in the Indian subcontinent and its diaspora. It includes works in many languages, such as Sanskrit, Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Gujarati, and English. Indian literature reflects the rich and diverse cultural heritage of India, as well as its history, philosophy, religion, and social issues.
- Indian culture is the collective way of life, values, beliefs, customs, and traditions of the people of India. It is influenced by various factors, such as geography, climate, history, religion, ethnicity, and languages. Indian culture is known for its diversity and unity, as well as its artistic, scientific, and spiritual achievements. Some of the aspects of Indian culture are greetings, religious customs, festivals, family structure, marriage, symbols, cuisine, clothing, dances, epics, mythology, martial arts, and languages.
- Indian tradition is the set of practices and rituals that are followed by the people of India, either as part of their religion or culture. Some of the common Indian traditions are yoga, meditation, ayurveda, astrology, vegetarianism, respect for elders, hospitality, joint family system, arranged marriages, dowry, caste system, and social hierarchy. Indian tradition

also includes various forms of folk art, music, and literature, such as Sama Veda, Ramayana, Mahabharata, Bhagavad Gita, Panchatantra, Kathakali, Bharatanatyam, and Bhangra.

- Indian practices are the actions and behaviors that are performed by the people of India, either as part of their daily life or on special occasions. Some of the common Indian practices are namaste, pranam, aarti, puja, havan, fasting, pilgrimage, charity, karma, reincarnation, samsara, moksha, dharma, ahimsa, satyagraha, swadeshi, and swaraj. Indian practices also include various forms of social service, education, science, technology, and innovation, such as Nalanda, Takshashila, zero, decimal system, surgery, metallurgy, and chess.

### Evolution of script in India

- A script is a written symbolisation of speech. It consists of a set of symbols or characters that represent the sounds of a language.
- India has a long and rich history of writing, dating back to the third millennium BCE. India has also been a multilingual and multicultural society, with different scripts used for different languages and regions.
- The earliest known script in India is the Indus script, which was used by the Indus Valley Civilization (c. 2500-1900 BCE). The Indus script is still undeciphered and its linguistic affiliation is unknown.
- The next major script in India is the Brahmi script, which was used to write the Prakrit languages, such as Pali and Magadhi, as well as Sanskrit. The Brahmi script is derived from the Aramaic script, which was brought to India by the Persian Empire in the sixth century BCE.
- The Brahmi script is the source of most modern Indian scripts, as well as the scripts of Sri Lanka, Tibet, Southeast Asia, and some parts of Central Asia. The Brahmi script evolved into different regional variants, such as Kharosthi, Gupta, Nagari, Siddham, and Grantha, depending on the local culture, geography, and writing material.
- The modern Indian scripts are classified into four main groups: the Northern group, the Southern group, the Eastern group, and the Western group. The Northern group includes Devanagari, Gujarati, Gurmukhi, and Nandinagari. The Southern group includes Kannada, Malayalam, Tamil, and Telugu. The Eastern group includes Assamese, Bengali, Odia, and Tibetan. The Western group includes Sindhi, Khojki, and Sharada.
- The modern Indian scripts have some common features, such as being alphasyllabic, meaning that each symbol represents a consonant-vowel syllable, and having a horizontal line at the top of the symbols, called the headstroke or shirorekha. The modern Indian scripts also have some differences, such as the shape and direction of the symbols, the presence or absence of vowel diacritics, and the use of conjuncts or ligatures for complex syllables.
- The evolution of script in India reflects the diversity and dynamism of the Indian culture and languages. The script is not only a means of

communication, but also a marker of identity, history, and art.

### **Evolution of languages in India**

- India is a multilingual country with over 780 languages spoken by its people.
- The linguistic history of India can be traced back to the prehistoric times when various language families emerged and interacted with each other.
- The major language families in India are the Indo-Aryan, the Dravidian, the Austroasiatic and the Sino-Tibetan.
- The Indo-Aryan languages are derived from the Indo-European languages that originated in Central Asia and spread to India through migrations and invasions. They are spoken by about 75% of the population and include languages such as Hindi, Bengali, Marathi, Urdu, Punjabi and Gujarati.
- The Dravidian languages are native to South India and are spoken by about 20% of the population. They include languages such as Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam and Tulu. The origin and relationship of the Dravidian languages with other language families are still debated by scholars.
- The Austroasiatic languages are spoken by about 3% of the population, mostly in the eastern and central regions of India. They include languages such as Santali, Mundari, Khasi and Munda. They are believed to be the oldest languages in India and have influenced the Indo-Aryan and the Dravidian languages.
- The Sino-Tibetan languages are spoken by about 1% of the population, mostly in the northeastern and northern regions of India. They include languages such as Tibetan, Manipuri, Bodo and Meitei. They are related to the languages spoken in China, Tibet, Myanmar and other neighboring countries.
- Apart from these language families, there are also some isolated languages such as Burushaski, Nihali and Andamanese that do not belong to any known language family.
- The evolution of Indian languages is also influenced by the contact and exchange with other cultures and languages, such as Persian, Arabic, Turkish, Portuguese, French and English.
- English, in particular, has played a significant role in the linguistic development of India since the colonial period. It is the official language of the Indian Union along with Hindi and is spoken as a second language by about 10% of the educated population. It has also enriched the Indian languages with many loanwords, expressions and grammatical features.
- The Indian languages are also dynamic and diverse, reflecting the social, cultural and regional variations of the speakers. They have developed many dialects, registers, styles and genres to suit different purposes and contexts.
- The Indian languages are also a source of identity, pride and heritage for

the people of India. They are a part of the rich and complex linguistic history of the subcontinent that continues to evolve and adapt to the changing times.

### **Harappan Script**

- Harappan script is the name given to the symbols found on the inscriptions and seals of the Indus Valley Civilisation, which flourished in the northwest of the Indian subcontinent from c. 2500 to 1900 BCE .
- Harappan script is not yet deciphered, and its underlying language(s) and meaning are unknown . Some scholars have proposed that it was a logo-syllabic system, where some symbols represented words or concepts, while others represented sounds. Others have suggested that it was a non-linguistic symbol system, used for religious or administrative purposes.
- Harappan script consists of about 400 signs, which vary in shape, size, orientation, and complexity . Some signs are pictographic, resembling objects or animals, while others are abstract or geometric. The signs are usually written from right to left, sometimes in a boustrophedon manner (alternating direction in each line) .
- Harappan script is mostly found on small objects, such as seals, tablets, pottery, and copper plates . The inscriptions are usually very short, ranging from one to 17 signs, with an average of five signs . The longest inscription, found on a signboard at Dholavira, has 10 signs. The inscriptions are often accompanied by images of animals, humans, or religious symbols .
- Harappan script is one of the oldest writing systems in the world, and a major source of information about the Indus Valley Civilisation . However, its interpretation remains a challenge for scholars, and many attempts to decipher it have been controversial or inconclusive . The discovery of a bilingual inscription or a Rosetta Stone-like object could help to unlock the secrets of Harappan script in the future .

### **Brahmi Script**

- Brahmi script is the earliest writing system developed in India after the Indus script.
- It is one of the most influential writing systems; all modern Indian scripts and several hundred scripts found in Southeast and East Asia are derived from Brahmi .
- Brahmi script appeared as a fully developed script in the third century BCE .
- Brahmi script is mentioned in the ancient Indian texts of Hinduism, Jainism and Buddhism, as well as their Chinese translations.
- Brahmi script was already divided into regional variants at the time of the earliest surviving epigraphy around the third century BC.



- Brahmi script is thought to have been modelled on the Aramaic or Phoenician alphabets, or possibly derived from the Indus or Harappa script .
- Brahmi script consists of 33 consonants and 9 vowels, and is written from left to right.
- Brahmi script has a distinctive horizontal line at the top of each character, called the headstroke.
- Brahmi script uses diacritical marks to indicate vowel sounds, and conjuncts to indicate combinations of consonants.
- Brahmi script has several numerical symbols for 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 10, 20, 100, and 1000.

### **The Vedas**

- The Vedas are a large body of religious texts originating in ancient India.
- The Vedas are composed in Vedic Sanskrit, the oldest layer of Sanskrit literature and the oldest scriptures of Hinduism.
- The word Veda means “knowledge” in Sanskrit, and the Vedas are thought to contain the fundamental knowledge relating to the underlying cause of, function of, and personal response to existence.
- The Vedas are divided into four collections: the Rigveda, the Yajurveda, the Samaveda and the Atharvaveda.
- The Rigveda is the oldest and most important of the Vedas, containing 1,028 hymns to various gods and natural phenomena.
- The Yajurveda contains the formulas and rituals for performing sacrifices and ceremonies.
- The Samaveda consists of musical chants and melodies for the Rigvedic hymns.
- The Atharvaveda contains spells, charms, and magical incantations for various purposes.
- The Vedas have regulated the social, legal, domestic and religious customs of Hindus up to the present day.
- The Vedas are considered to be revealed by the gods to the sages, and are therefore regarded as sacred and authoritative.

### **The Upanishads**

- The Upanishads are ancient Hindu scriptures that explore the nature of reality, the self, and the supreme being.
- The word Upanishad means “to sit down closely”, implying the intimate relationship between the teacher and the student who receive the secret teachings.
- The Upanishads are considered the end or the essence of the Vedas, the oldest and most authoritative Hindu texts .
- There are more than 200 Upanishads, but only 13 are considered the principal or the most important ones. They are: Isha, Kena, Katha, Prashna, Mundaka, Mandukya, Taittiriya, Aitareya, Chandogya, Brihadaranyaka,

Kaushitaki, Shvetashvatara, and Maitri.

- The Upanishads contain various philosophical concepts and doctrines, such as the idea of Brahman, the ultimate reality that pervades everything; the idea of Atman, the true self or soul that is identical with Brahman; the idea of Maya, the illusion or ignorance that prevents one from realizing one's true nature; the idea of Karma, the law of cause and effect that determines one's destiny; the idea of Samsara, the cycle of birth and death that traps one in suffering; the idea of Moksha, the liberation or freedom from Samsara; and the idea of Dharma, the moral duty or righteousness that guides one's actions .
- The Upanishads also present various methods and practices to attain Moksha, such as meditation, yoga, renunciation, ethical conduct, devotion, and self-inquiry .
- The Upanishads have influenced many schools of Hindu philosophy, such as Vedanta, Yoga, Samkhya, Nyaya, and Mimamsa, as well as other religions and traditions, such as Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism, and Neo-Vedanta .

### **The Ramayana**

- The Ramayana is a Hindu epic about the life of the legendary Prince Rama of Kosala .
- Rama is the virtuous, wise, and powerful son of King Dasaratha, who wants him to succeed him as king .
- Rama marries the beautiful Sita, the princess of Mithila, after lifting and stringing the bow of Siva, a divine challenge that no other man can accomplish .
- Rama is exiled from his homeland for 14 years by his stepmother Kaikeyi, who wants her son Bharata to be king instead .
- Rama, Sita, and Rama's brother Lakshmana go to the forest, where they encounter many sages, friends, and foes .
- Ravana, the demon king of Lanka, abducts Sita with the help of his sister Surpanakha and his uncle Maricha .
- Rama and Lakshmana search for Sita, aided by the monkey king Sugriva and his general Hanuman .
- Rama and his allies build a bridge to Lanka and wage a war against Ravana and his army .
- Rama kills Ravana with a special arrow and rescues Sita, who proves her chastity by undergoing a fire test .
- Rama, Sita, and Lakshmana return to Ayodhya, where Rama is crowned as king and rules with justice and peace .

### **The Mahabharata**

- The Mahabharata is one of the two major Sanskrit epics of India, along with the Ramayana .

- It is a long and complex narrative that covers the history, culture, religion, and philosophy of ancient India.
- It tells the story of the conflict between two groups of cousins, the Kauravas and the Pandavas, who fight for the throne of Hastinapura, a kingdom in northern India .
- The main plot of the Mahabharata is the Kurukshetra War, a 18-day battle that involves various kings, gods, and warriors.
- The Mahabharata also contains many sub-stories, such as the Bhagavad Gita, a dialogue between the Pandava prince Arjuna and the god Krishna, who advises him on his duty and dharma.
- The Mahabharata is considered to be both a historical account of the origins of Hinduism and a code of ethics for the faithful.
- The Mahabharata is divided into 18 books, or parvas, that contain about 74,000 verses and 1.8 million words in total.
- The Mahabharata is attributed to the sage Vyasa, who is also a character in the story. However, it is likely that the Mahabharata was composed by multiple authors over centuries.
- The Mahabharata is a rich source of literature, art, and culture for India and the world. It has been translated, adapted, and retold in various languages and media.

## Puranas

- Puranas are a genre of ancient Indian literature that contain stories, legends, myths, cosmology, genealogy, and other topics related to Hinduism .
- Puranas are written in Sanskrit verse and are considered as the fifth Veda, after the four Vedas and the Upanishads .
- Puranas are classified into two categories: Mahapuranas (major Puranas) and Upapuranas (minor Puranas). There are 18 Mahapuranas and 18 Upapuranas, each devoted to a different deity, such as Vishnu, Shiva, Brahma, Devi, etc .
- Puranas are not uniform in content, style, or date of composition. They vary widely in their length, scope, and quality. Some Puranas are very ancient, dating back to the 4th century BCE, while others are relatively recent, dating to the medieval or modern period .
- Puranas are known for their symbolic and allegorical interpretation of Hindu philosophy, ethics, and cosmology. They also contain historical information, such as the dynasties of kings, the lineage of sages, the description of sacred places, etc .
- Puranas are popular and influential sources of Hindu culture, religion, and spirituality. They are widely read, recited, and performed by Hindus of different sects, regions, and languages .

### **Buddhist Literature in Pali, Prakrit and Sanskrit**

- Buddhist literature is the collection of writings that preserve the teachings and traditions of Buddhism.
- Pali, Prakrit and Sanskrit are three ancient languages that were used to compose Buddhist texts in different regions and periods of history.
- Pali is a Middle Indo-Aryan language that is closely related to the language spoken by the Buddha in the 6th century BCE. It is the canonical language of Theravada Buddhism, the oldest surviving branch of Buddhism. Pali literature includes the Tipitaka (the three baskets of scriptures), the commentaries, the sub-commentaries, and the chronicles.
- Prakrit is a generic term for any Middle Indo-Aryan language that is derived from Sanskrit. There are many varieties of Prakrit, such as Sauraseni, Maharastri, Magadhi and Gandhari. Prakrit literature includes the canonical texts of Mahayana Buddhism, the heterodox sects of Buddhism, and the Jaina tradition. Prakrit literature also includes secular works such as poetry, drama, and inscriptions.
- Sanskrit is a classical Indo-Aryan language that is the primary language of Hinduism and a major literary language of India. Sanskrit literature includes the later developments of Mahayana Buddhism, such as the Mahayana sutras, the tantras, the shastras, and the biographies of Buddhist masters. Sanskrit literature also includes the works of Buddhist philosophers, poets, and scholars, such as Nagarjuna, Asvaghosa, and Dignaga.

### **Jain Literature in Pali, Prakrit and Sanskrit**

- Jain literature refers to the literature of the Jain religion, which is one of the oldest and major religions of India.
- Jain literature is a vast and ancient literary tradition, which was initially transmitted orally by the teachers and disciples of Jainism.
- Jain literature is composed in various languages, such as Prakrit, Pali, Sanskrit, Apabhramsha, Hindi, Gujarati, Tamil, Kannada, and Rajasthani.
- The most important and authoritative Jain literature is the canonical literature, which consists of the sacred scriptures of the Jains, known as the Agamas or Siddhantas.
- The canonical literature is written in Ardhamagadhi, a Prakrit language that was spoken by Mahavira, the 24th and last Tirthankara (ford-maker) of Jainism.
- The canonical literature is divided into two main categories: the Angas (limbs) and the Upangas (subsidiary limbs). The Angas are 12 in number and contain the core teachings of Jainism, such as the doctrine of karma, the theory of non-violence, the code of conduct, and the cosmology. The Upangas are 12 in number and contain supplementary teachings, such as the legends of the Tirthankaras, the stories of the previous lives of Mahavira, the description of the six substances, and the classification of living beings.

- The canonical literature also includes other texts, such as the Prakirnas (miscellaneous), the Chhedasutras (disciplinary), the Mulasutras (fundamental), and the Nandisutras (introductory).
- The canonical literature was compiled and edited by the councils of Jain monks, who also added commentaries and sub-commentaries to the original texts. The first council was held at Pataliputra (modern Patna) in the 4th century BCE, the second at Mathura in the 2nd or 3rd century CE, and the third at Valabhi in Gujarat in the 5th or 6th century CE.
- The canonical literature is preserved by two main sects of Jainism: the Svetambaras (white-clad) and the Digambaras (sky-clad). The Svetambaras accept all the 45 texts of the canonical literature as authentic, while the Digambaras reject some of them and consider only 32 texts as genuine. The Digambaras also claim that some of the original texts were lost or corrupted over time, and therefore they rely more on the later works of their scholars and saints.
- Jain literature also includes non-canonical literature, which consists of various works of literature, philosophy, grammar, poetry, drama, history, biography, art, and science, written by Jain authors in different languages and periods. Some of the prominent Jain authors are Kundakunda, Umasvati, Haribhadra, Hemacandra, Jinasena, Somadeva, Banarasidas, and Jnaneshvara.
- Jain literature in Pali and Prakrit is mostly related to the canonical literature and its commentaries, as well as some works of grammar, lexicography, and poetry. Jain literature in Sanskrit is more diverse and covers a wide range of topics, such as logic, metaphysics, ethics, aesthetics, mathematics, astronomy, astrology, medicine, and alchemy. Jain literature in other languages reflects the regional and cultural influences of Jainism and its interaction with other traditions and communities.

### **Kautilya's Arthashastra**

- Kautilya's Arthashastra is an ancient Indian treatise on statecraft, politics, economics, military strategy, and social organization.
- It is attributed to Kautilya, also known as Chanakya, Vishnugupta, or the Prime Minister of the Mauryan Empire under Chandragupta Maurya (c. 321-c. 297 BCE).
- The Arthashastra consists of 15 books, 150 chapters, and about 6000 verses. It covers topics such as the nature and duties of the king, the structure and functions of the government, the principles of foreign policy, the methods of warfare and espionage, the laws and administration of justice, the taxation and revenue system, the welfare and protection of the people, and the ethical and moral values of the society.
- The Arthashastra is considered one of the earliest and most comprehensive works on political science and public administration in the world. It reflects the political, social, and economic conditions of ancient India, as well as the influence of other cultures and civilizations, such as Persia,

Greece, and China.

- The Arthashastra is based on the concept of artha, which means material wealth, prosperity, and security. Kautilya advocates a pragmatic and rational approach to governance, with the aim of maximizing the welfare and happiness of the people, while maintaining the stability and sovereignty of the state. He also emphasizes the importance of ethics, morality, and dharma (duty) in the conduct of the ruler and the citizens.
- The Arthashastra is a source of inspiration and guidance for many modern scholars, leaders, and thinkers, who have applied its principles and insights to various fields and contexts, such as political science, economics, law, management, diplomacy, and strategy.

### Famous Sanskrit Authors in India

Sanskrit is one of the oldest and most influential languages in India. It has a rich literary tradition that spans over two millennia. Many Sanskrit authors have contributed to various genres of literature, such as poetry, drama, philosophy, grammar, and religious texts. Here are some of the famous Sanskrit authors in India:

- **Kalidasa:** He is considered to be the greatest Sanskrit poet and dramatist in India. He lived in the 4th or 5th century CE, during the Gupta dynasty. He wrote three epic poems (Mahakavyas), namely Raghuvamsa, Kumarasambhava, and Meghaduta. He also wrote three plays, namely Malavikagnimitra, Vikramorvasiya, and Abhijnanasakuntala. His works are known for their lyrical beauty, romantic charm, and cultural sophistication.
- **Bhasa:** He is one of the earliest and most prolific Sanskrit dramatists in India. He lived around the 3rd century CE, but his works were rediscovered in the 20th century. He wrote thirteen plays, mostly based on the epics Mahabharata and Ramayana. His plays are known for their dramatic intensity, psychological realism, and tragic endings. Some of his famous plays are Urubhanga, Madhyamavyayoga, and Svapnavasavadatta.
- **Bhartrihari:** He is a renowned Sanskrit poet and philosopher in India. He lived in the 5th or 6th century CE, and is said to be the brother of King Vikramaditya. He wrote three collections of verses (Satakas), namely Nitisataka, Srngarasataka, and Vairagyasataka. His verses deal with ethical, erotic, and spiritual themes, and are known for their wit, wisdom, and eloquence.
- **Banabhatta:** He is a celebrated Sanskrit poet and biographer in India. He lived in the 7th century CE, and was the court poet of King Harshavardhana. He wrote two epic poems, namely Harshacharita and Kadambari. His works are known for their complex plot, elaborate style, and vivid description of the contemporary society.
- **Gajapati Purusottama Deva:** He is a rare example of a Sanskrit poet who was also a powerful king in India. He ruled over Orissa in the 15th cen-

tury CE, and was a patron of art and culture. He wrote five works, namely Muklichintamani, Gopalarchana vidhi, Nama Malika, Durogotsava, and Bhubaneswari Pujapallava. His works are devoted to the worship of Lord Krishna and Goddess Bhubaneswari.

- **Satyavrat Shastri:** He is a modern Sanskrit poet and scholar in India. He was born in 1930, and is still active in the field of Sanskrit literature. He has written two epic poems, namely Ramakirtimahakavyam and Brahattaram Bharatam. He has also written several shorter poems, plays, and essays on various topics. He is the first and only Sanskrit author to win the Jnanpith Award, India's highest literary honor, in 2009.

### Telugu Literature

- Telugu literature is the body of works written in the Telugu language, a Dravidian language spoken mainly in the Indian states of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana.
- Telugu literature consists of various genres, such as poetry, prose, drama, folklore, and song lyrics. Some of the prominent forms of Telugu literature are śataka, padya, kāvya, prabandha, campū, yakṣagāna, harikatha, and burrakatha.
- Telugu literature has a long and rich history, dating back to at least the 11th century CE, when the poet Nannaya translated the Mahabharata into Telugu. Some of the other notable early Telugu poets are Tikkana, Errana, Nannayya, Srinatha, Potana, and Allasani Peddana.
- Telugu literature flourished under the patronage of various dynasties, such as the Chalukyas, the Kakatiyas, the Vijayanagara Empire, the Qutb Shahis, and the Mughals. Some of the influential Telugu literary figures from these periods are Vemana, Annamacharya, Kshetravaya, Bhadrachala Ramadasa, Kancharla Gopanna, and Tyagaraja.
- Telugu literature also witnessed a modern renaissance in the 19th and 20th centuries, with the emergence of social reform movements, nationalist movements, and literary movements, such as the Romantic, the Progressive, the Digambara, and the Dalit. Some of the prominent modern Telugu writers are Gurajada Apparao, Viswanatha Satyanarayana, Sri Sri, Jashuva, Gopichand, Chalam, Ravi Sastry, C. Narayana Reddy, and Mahasweta Devi.

### Kannada Literature

- Kannada literature is the body of written works in the Kannada language, a member of the Dravidian family spoken mainly in the Indian state of Karnataka and written in the Kannada script .
- The earliest records in Kannada are inscriptions dating from the 6th century AD onward. The oldest existing literary work in Kannada is the Kavi-rajamarga, a treatise on poetics, written by King Nripatunga Amoghavarsha I in the 9th century.

- Kannada literature has been classified into three main periods: Old Kannada (9th to 14th century), Middle Kannada (14th to 18th century) and Modern Kannada (19th century to present).
- Some of the notable genres of Kannada literature include poetry, prose, drama, biography, history, grammar, philosophy, rhetoric, chronicles, cuisine, dictionaries and encyclopedias .
- Some of the prominent writers of Kannada literature include Pampa, Ranna, Harihara, Basavanna, Akka Mahadevi, Kumara Vyasa, Purandara Dasa, Kanaka Dasa, Sarvajna, Lakshmisha, Ponna, Raghavanka, Andayya, Ratnakaravarni, Chamarasa, Kumaravyasa, Nanjunda Kavi, Bendre, Kuvempu, Shivaram Karanth, Masti Venkatesha Iyengar, U.R. Ananthamurthy, Girish Karnad, S.L. Bhyrappa, Chandrashekhara Kambara and others .
- Kannada literature has been recognized by several awards, such as the Jnanpith Award, the Sahitya Akademi Award, the Pampa Award, the Karnataka Sahitya Academy Award, the Ananda Coomaraswamy Fellowship and others .
- Kannada literature has also influenced other languages and literatures, such as Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Marathi, Hindi, English and others .

### Malayalam Literature

- Malayalam literature is the literature written in Malayalam, a South-Dravidian language spoken in the Indian state of Kerala.
- The earliest extant literary work in Malayalam is Ramacharitam, a narrative poem based on the Ramayana, composed in the late 12th or early 13th century .
- Malayalam literature has a rich and diverse history, influenced by Sanskrit, Tamil, Arabic, Portuguese, English and other languages .
- Malayalam literature can be broadly divided into four periods: classical, medieval, modern and contemporary.
- The classical period (13th to 16th century) witnessed the emergence of various genres such as Manipravalam, Champu, Sandesa Kavya, Kathakali and Thullal . Some of the prominent writers of this period are Ezhuthachan, Kunchan Nambiar, Melpathur Narayana Bhattathiri and Unnayi Warriar .
- The medieval period (17th to 19th century) saw the development of prose, novel, drama, biography, travelogue and journalism in Malayalam literature . Some of the notable writers of this period are Thunchaththu Ramanujan Ezhuthachan, Kottarathil Sankunni, Kerala Varma Valiya Koil Thampuran and C. V. Raman Pillai .
- The modern period (20th century) was marked by the emergence of social realism, romanticism, progressive movement, modernism, postmodernism and other literary trends in Malayalam literature . Some of the influential writers of this period are Kumaran Asan, Vallathol Narayana Menon, Ulloor S. Parameswara Iyer, G. Sankara Kurup, Thakazhi Sivasankara Pillai,



Vaikom Muhammad Basheer, M. T. Vasudevan Nair, O. V. Vijayan and Kamala Surayya .

- The contemporary period (21st century) is characterized by the diversity and experimentation of Malayalam literature, reflecting the changes in society, culture, politics and technology . Some of the prominent writers of this period are M. Mukundan, Sethu, K. R. Meera, Benyamin, Anand, N. S. Madhavan and K. Satchidanandan .
- Malayalam literature has also produced many acclaimed poets, critics, translators, editors, publishers and scholars who have contributed to the enrichment and recognition of the language and literature .

: **Malayalam literature - Wikipedia** Malayalam literature | Facts, Writers, Poetry, & Examples  
 | Malayalam Literature Magazine ...

### Sangama Literature in India

- Sangama literature is the earliest known literature in the Tamil language, composed between the 1st and 4th centuries CE by poets belonging to three literary academies (sangams) in Madurai, India .
- Sangama literature consists of 18 works, including eight anthologies of poems (Ettuthokai), ten long poems (Pattuppattu), and a grammar treatise (Tolkappiyam) .
- Sangama literature is broadly classified into two genres: akam (inner) and puram (outer) . Akam poems deal with love, romance, and eroticism, while puram poems deal with heroism, war, and public life .
- Sangama literature reflects the social, cultural, religious, and political aspects of ancient Tamil society, as well as the natural beauty and diversity of the Tamil land .
- Sangama literature is considered to be a valuable source of information on the history, geography, and culture of ancient South India, as well as the development of the Tamil language and literature .

### Northern Indian languages

- Northern Indian languages are mainly from the Indo-Aryan branch of the Indo-European language family .
- They include the Hindustani lingua franca, which has two standard forms: Hindi and Urdu . Hindi is the official language of India and Urdu is the official language of Pakistan.
- They also include a variety of regional languages and dialects, such as Punjabi, Kashmiri, Pahari, Sindhi, Bihari, Rajasthani, Marwari, and Gujarati .
- Some of these languages have their own scripts, such as Devanagari for Hindi, Urdu, and Marathi; Gurmukhi for Punjabi; and Perso-Arabic for Urdu and Kashmiri. Others use the Latin alphabet or other scripts for writing.

- These languages have been influenced by various historical and cultural factors, such as Sanskrit, Persian, Arabic, Turkish, English, and local languages .
- These languages have rich literary traditions, such as the poetry of Mirza Ghalib, the novels of Premchand, the epics of Tulsidas, and the folk songs of Lata Mangeshkar.
- These languages are spoken by millions of people across India, Pakistan, Nepal, Bangladesh, and other countries. They are also used as lingua francas in many regions and communities.

### **North Indian Literature**

- North Indian literature refers to the literature produced in the languages of northern India, such as Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi, Kashmiri, Rajasthani, etc.
- North Indian literature is influenced by the ancient Indian background, which includes two Sanskrit epic poems, the Mahabharata and Ramayana, as well as the Bhagavata-purana and the other Puranas.
- North Indian literature also reflects the cultural and religious diversity of the region, as well as the historical and political events that shaped its history, such as the Delhi Sultanate, the Mughal Empire, the British Raj, the Partition, and the Independence.
- Some of the prominent genres of North Indian literature are poetry, drama, novel, short story, essay, biography, autobiography, and travelogue.
- Some of the notable writers of North Indian literature are Kabir, Tulsidas, Mirabai, Surdas, Amir Khusrow, Mir Taqi Mir, Ghalib, Premchand, Bhisham Sahni, Amrita Pritam, Munshi Premchand, Rajendra Yadav, Nirmal Verma, Mahadevi Varma, Harivansh Rai Bachchan, etc.
- North Indian literature is also enriched by the literature from Northeast India, which is a region with rich cultural and ethnolinguistic diversity, and represents varied histories, languages, socio-cultural and religious practices .
- Some of the prominent writers of Northeast Indian literature are Birendra Kumar Bhattacharya, Mamoni Raisom Goswami, Indira Goswami, Temsula Ao, Mitra Phukan, Easterine Kire, Arupa Patangia Kalita, etc.

### **Persian Literature in India**

- Persian literature in India refers to the literary works produced in the Persian language by writers, poets, historians, and scholars who lived in the Indian subcontinent or visited it.
- Persian literature in India began with the rise of the Delhi Sultanate in the 13th century, when Persian became the official language of the courts and the administration. The Delhi Sultanate rulers patronized Persian poets, scholars, and historians, who produced works on various subjects, such as history, geography, religion, ethics, philosophy, and mysticism. Some

of the notable Persian writers of this period were Amir Khusrow, Minhaj al-Siraj, Ziauddin Barani, and Shams al-Din Iltutmish.

- Persian literature in India reached its peak during the Mughal Empire, which ruled most of India from the 16th to the 18th century. The Mughal emperors, especially Akbar, Jahangir, and Shah Jahan, were themselves well-versed in Persian literature and culture, and encouraged the development of Persian poetry, prose, and historiography. Some of the famous Persian writers of this era were Abul Fazl, Faizi, Nizamuddin Ahmad, Abdul Qadir Badauni, and Muhammad Qasim Firishta.
- Persian literature in India also flourished in the regional kingdoms and states that emerged after the decline of the Mughal Empire, such as the Deccan Sultanates, the Awadh Nawabs, the Bengal Nawabs, and the Hyderabad Nizams. These rulers and their nobles also supported Persian poets, historians, and scholars, who wrote works on local history, culture, politics, and society. Some of the prominent Persian writers of this period were Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah, Mirza Muhammad Rafi Sauda, Mir Taqi Mir, Ghulam Ali Azad Bilgrami, and Sirajuddaula.
- Persian literature in India declined in the 19th century, as the British colonial rule gradually replaced Persian with English as the language of administration and education. However, some Persian writers continued to produce works in the fields of literature, history, and religion, such as Mirza Ghalib, Mirza Asadullah Khan Ghalib, Muhammad Iqbal, and Abul Kalam Azad.
- Persian literature in India is a rich and diverse body of literature that reflects the interaction and exchange of ideas, values, and cultures between Persia and India over centuries. It is a valuable source of information and insight into the history, society, and civilization of both regions. It is also a testament to the enduring influence and legacy of Persian language and literature in the Indian subcontinent.

### **Urdu Literature in India**

- Urdu literature is the literature written in the Urdu language, which is spoken by the Muslims of Pakistan and northern India .
- Urdu literature is influenced by the Persian, Arabic, and Turkish languages, as well as the local languages of the Indian subcontinent, such as Hindi, Punjabi, Sindhi, and Gujarati.
- Urdu literature is known for its poetry, especially the forms of ghazal and nazm, which are lyrical expressions of love, longing, and mysticism. Some of the famous Urdu poets are Mirza Ghalib, Mir Taqi Mir, Allama Iqbal, Faiz Ahmed Faiz, and Ahmad Faraz.
- Urdu literature also includes prose genres, such as novels, short stories, essays, and biographies. Some of the notable Urdu prose writers are Premchand, Saadat Hasan Manto, Ismat Chughtai, Qurratulain Hyder, and Khushwant Singh.
- Urdu literature has a rich and diverse history, spanning from the medieval

period to the modern era, and reflecting the social, political, and cultural changes in the Indian subcontinent. Urdu literature has also contributed to the development of other literary traditions, such as Hindi literature, Bengali literature, and Pakistani literature.

### **Hindi Literature**

Hindi literature is the literature written in the Hindi language, which includes various dialects and scripts. Hindi literature has a long and rich history, dating back to the 11th century. Some of the main features and topics of Hindi literature are:

- Hindi literature is divided into four periods: Adikal (the early period), Bhaktikal (the devotional period), Ritikal (the scholastic period) and Adhunik (the modern period).
- Hindi literature is influenced by Sanskrit, Prakrit, Pali, Persian, Arabic, Urdu and English languages and literatures.
- Hindi literature reflects the religious, social, cultural and political aspects of India, such as Hinduism, Islam, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism, nationalism, colonialism, feminism, etc.
- Hindi literature has various genres and forms, such as poetry, prose, drama, novel, short story, essay, biography, autobiography, travelogue, etc.
- Hindi literature has produced many eminent writers and works, such as Kabir, Tulsidas, Surdas, Mirabai, Premchand, Jaishankar Prasad, Mahadevi Varma, Harivansh Rai Bachchan, Munshi Premchand, Bhisam Sahni, Nirmal Verma, etc.

### **Module 3- Indian Religion, Philosophy, and Practices**

- India is a diverse and pluralistic country, where many religions and philosophies coexist and influence each other.
- The major religions in India are Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Sikhism, Islam, and Christianity. There are also smaller communities of Jews, Zoroastrians, Bahá'ís, and others.
- Hinduism is the oldest and largest religion in India, with about 80% of the population identifying as Hindus. Hinduism is a complex and diverse tradition, with many sects, schools, and practices. Hinduism is based on the Vedas, the ancient scriptures that contain hymns, rituals, and philosophy. Hinduism believes in the concepts of karma, dharma, reincarnation, and moksha (liberation from the cycle of birth and death).
- Buddhism originated in India in the 6th century BCE, when Siddhartha Gautama, known as the Buddha, attained enlightenment and taught the Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path. Buddhism spread throughout Asia and beyond, and developed into various branches, such as Theravada, Mahayana, and Vajrayana. Buddhism teaches the principles of non-violence, compassion, wisdom, and meditation. Buddhism has about

7% of the population in India, mostly in the northeastern states and among the Dalits (formerly known as untouchables).

- Jainism is another ancient religion that emerged in India around the same time as Buddhism. Jainism emphasizes the practice of ahimsa (non-violence), anekantavada (non-absolutism), and aparigraha (non-attachment). Jainism believes in the existence of jivas (souls) and ajivas (non-souls), and the possibility of attaining kevala (omniscience) and nirvana (liberation) by following the five vows of non-violence, truth, non-stealing, celibacy, and non-possession. Jainism has about 0.4% of the population in India, mostly concentrated in the western and northern states.
- Sikhism is a monotheistic religion that originated in the 15th century CE, when Guru Nanak and his nine successors, known as the Gurus, preached the message of one God, equality, service, and justice. Sikhism is based on the Guru Granth Sahib, the holy scripture that contains the teachings of the Gurus and other saints. Sikhism believes in the concepts of naam (divine name), shabad (divine word), and sangat (congregation). Sikhism has about 2% of the population in India, mostly in the state of Punjab and the national capital region of Delhi.
- Islam is the second-largest religion in India, with about 14% of the population identifying as Muslims. Islam was introduced to India by Arab traders, invaders, and Sufi saints, and flourished under various Muslim dynasties and empires. Islam is a monotheistic religion that follows the Quran, the holy book revealed to Prophet Muhammad, and the Sunnah, the example of his life and teachings. Islam believes in the concepts of tawhid (oneness of God), sharia (Islamic law), and akhirah (afterlife). Islam has many sects and schools, such as Sunni, Shia, Sufi, and Ahmadiyya.
- Christianity is the third-largest religion in India, with about 2.3% of the population identifying as Christians. Christianity was brought to India by various missionaries, such as Thomas the Apostle, Saint Francis Xavier, and William Carey. Christianity is a monotheistic religion that follows the Bible, the holy book that contains the Old and New Testaments. Christianity believes in the concepts of Trinity (Father, Son, and Holy Spirit), incarnation (God becoming human in Jesus Christ), and salvation (forgiveness of sins and eternal life). Christianity has many denominations and traditions, such as Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant, and Pentecostal.

### **Pre-Vedic Religion in India**

- Pre-Vedic religion refers to the religious beliefs and practices of the people who lived in the Indus Valley or Harappan civilization, before the arrival of the Indo-Aryan speakers who brought the Vedic religion to India.
- The Pre-Vedic religion was mainly based on the worship of natural forces and fertility deities, such as the Mother Goddess, the Bull, the Pashupati (Lord of Animals), and the Pipal tree.
- The Pre-Vedic religion also involved the use of seals, amulets, terracotta

figurines, and fire altars, which suggest some form of ritual and magic.

- The Pre-Vedic religion did not have a written scripture, but relied on oral transmission and symbolism.
- The Pre-Vedic religion was largely replaced by the Vedic religion, which was brought by the Indo-Aryan speakers who migrated to India from the Central Asian steppes around 1500 BCE.
- The Vedic religion was based on the worship of many gods, such as Indra, Varuna, Agni, Surya, and Rudra, who represented different aspects of nature and cosmic order .
- The Vedic religion also involved the performance of sacrifices (yajna) and the recitation of hymns (mantra) from the sacred texts known as the Vedas, which are the oldest scriptures of Hinduism.
- The Vedic religion evolved over time and gave rise to various schools of thought and sects, such as the Upanishads, the Brahmanas, the Sutras, and the Vedanta.
- The Vedic religion is considered the oldest stratum of religious activity in India, and the foundation of Hinduism.

### **Vedic Religion in India**

- Vedic religion was the religion of the ancient Indo-European-speaking peoples who entered India about 1500 BCE from the region of present-day Iran.
- It takes its name from the collections of sacred texts known as the Vedas, which are the oldest stratum of religious activity in India for which there exist written materials.
- The Vedas are composed in Vedic Sanskrit and consist of four collections: the Rigveda, the Yajurveda, the Samaveda and the Atharvaveda.
- The Vedic religion was based on the performance of sacrifices (yajna) to various gods (devas) who represented natural forces or aspects of the cosmic order.
- The Vedic religion also involved the worship of fire (agni), the sun (surya), the dawn (ushas), the storm (indra), the soma plant (soma), and other deities.
- The Vedic religion was characterized by a hierarchical social structure, with priests (brahmins) at the top, followed by warriors (kshatriyas), commoners (vaishyas), and servants (shudras).
- The Vedic religion also developed the concepts of karma, reincarnation, dharma, and the four stages of life (ashrama).
- The Vedic religion gradually evolved into the later forms of Hinduism, such as Brahmanism, Upanishadism, and Vedanta.

### **Buddhism in India**

- Buddhism is an ancient Indian religion that originated in the 6th century BCE in the region of Magadha (now Bihar) and spread throughout

northern India and beyond .

- Buddhism is based on the teachings and life experiences of Siddhartha Gautama, who became known as the Buddha (the awakened one) after attaining enlightenment under a bodhi tree .
- Buddhism teaches the four noble truths: the truth of suffering, the truth of the cause of suffering, the truth of the end of suffering, and the truth of the path that leads to the end of suffering .
- Buddhism also teaches the eightfold path: right view, right intention, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, and right concentration .
- Buddhism is divided into two main branches: Theravada and Mahayana. Theravada Buddhism follows the Pali canon, the oldest collection of Buddhist scriptures, and emphasizes the individual attainment of nirvana, the state of liberation from the cycle of rebirth. Mahayana Buddhism follows the Sanskrit scriptures, which include additional teachings and stories, and emphasizes the bodhisattva ideal, the aspiration to become a compassionate being who helps others to attain enlightenment .
- Buddhism flourished in India for over a thousand years, from the 3rd century BCE to the 12th century CE, and produced many schools, sects, and traditions, such as the Madhyamaka, Yogacara, Pure Land, Zen, and Vajrayana. Buddhism also influenced Indian art, architecture, literature, philosophy, and culture .
- Buddhism spread from India to other parts of Asia, such as Central Asia, China, Tibet, Japan, Korea, Sri Lanka, and Southeast Asia, through trade, pilgrimage, and missionary activities. India was regarded as the sacred land of Buddhism by many Asian Buddhists .
- Buddhism declined in India from the 8th century CE onwards, due to various factors, such as the rise of Hinduism, the invasions of Muslim rulers, the corruption and degeneration of Buddhist monasteries, and the loss of patronage and support from the laity. Buddhism survived in some regions, such as Ladakh, Sikkim, and Arunachal Pradesh, and was revived in the 20th century by the Dalit Buddhist movement and the Tibetan refugees .
- Buddhism is currently the fourth largest religion in India, with about 8.4 million followers, or 0.7% of the population, according to the 2011 census. Most Indian Buddhists belong to the Dalit, Tibetan, or Nepali communities. Buddhism is also practiced by some members of other religions, such as Hinduism, Jainism, and Sikhism, as a form of spirituality or philosophy .

### **Jainism in India**

- Jainism is an ancient Indian religion that teaches the path to spiritual purity and enlightenment through nonviolence and reducing harm to all living beings .
- Jainism originated in India at least 2,500 years ago and is based on the teachings of 24 spiritual leaders called Tirthankaras, the last of whom was

Mahavira .

- Jains believe in the existence of an eternal soul that can be liberated from the cycle of rebirth and attain a state of omniscience and bliss called moksha .
- Jains follow five main principles: ahimsa (nonviolence), satya (truthfulness), asteya (non-stealing), brahmacharya (celibacy or chastity), and aparigraha (non-attachment or non-possessiveness) .
- Jains practice various rituals and ceremonies, such as fasting, meditation, worship, pilgrimage, festivals, and rites of passage .
- Jains are divided into two major sects: Digambara (sky-clad) and Svetambara (white-clad), which differ in their doctrines, practices, and traditions .
- Jains are a small but influential minority in India, constituting about 0.4% of the population, or about 4.5 million people .
- Jains are mostly concentrated in the states of Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, and Karnataka, but also have a presence in other parts of India and abroad .
- Jains are the most educated and affluent religious group in India, with high levels of literacy, employment, income, and social status .
- Jains have contributed significantly to the fields of art, architecture, literature, philosophy, science, and social reform in India and beyond .

## Six System Indian Philosophy

The six systems of Indian philosophy are Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Samkhya, Yoga, Purva Mimamsa and Uttara Mimamsa or Vedanta. They are also known as the orthodox schools of Hindu philosophy, as they accept the authority of the Vedas, the ancient scriptures of India. Each system has its own founder, texts, concepts and methods of inquiry. Here is a brief overview of each system:

- **Nyaya:** The founder of Nyaya is Akshapada Gautama and it dates back to 2nd Century BCE. It is a school that deals with logic and epistemology, or the theory of knowledge. It aims to establish the validity of sources of knowledge, such as perception, inference, analogy and testimony. It also develops rules of reasoning and debate to refute false views and establish true ones. Nyaya is often paired with Vaisheshika, as they share many concepts and categories .
- **Vaisheshika:** The founder of Vaisheshika is Kanada and it dates back to 6th Century BCE. It is a school that deals with metaphysics, or the nature of reality. It proposes that reality is composed of six categories of substances: atoms, qualities, actions, universals, inherence and absence. It also postulates that atoms are the ultimate indivisible particles of matter, and that they combine to form complex substances. Vaisheshika is often paired with Nyaya, as they share many concepts and categories .
- **Samkhya:** The founder of Samkhya is Kapila and it dates back to 6th Century BCE. It is a school that deals with cosmology, or the origin and



evolution of the universe. It proposes that reality is composed of two principles: purusha (consciousness) and prakriti (matter). It also explains how prakriti evolves into various elements, senses, mind and ego, and how purusha becomes bound and liberated from prakriti. Samkhya is often paired with Yoga, as they share many concepts and methods of liberation .

- **Yoga:** The founder of Yoga is Patanjali and it dates back to 2nd Century BCE. It is a school that deals with psychology, or the control and transformation of the mind. It prescribes an eightfold path of discipline and meditation to attain the state of samadhi, or the union of the individual self with the supreme self. It also describes various types of yoga, such as karma, bhakti, jnana and raja. Yoga is often paired with Samkhya, as they share many concepts and methods of liberation .
- **Purva Mimamsa:** The founder of Purva Mimamsa is Jaimini and it dates back to 3rd Century BCE. It is a school that deals with hermeneutics, or the interpretation of the Vedas. It aims to establish the authority and validity of the Vedas, and to derive the rules of dharma, or the moral and religious duty. It also analyzes the language and grammar of the Vedas, and the rituals and sacrifices prescribed by them. Purva Mimamsa is often paired with Uttara Mimamsa or Vedanta, as they are both based on the Vedas .
- **Uttara Mimamsa or Vedanta:** The founder of Uttara Mimamsa or Vedanta is Badarayana and it dates back to 4th Century BCE. It is a school that deals with ontology, or the nature of being. It is based on the Upanishads, the philosophical portions of the Vedas, and it aims to reveal the ultimate truth of Brahman, or the supreme reality. It also develops various sub-schools, such as Advaita, Vishishtadvaita and Dvaita, that differ in their views on the relation between Brahman, the individual self and the world. Uttara Mimamsa or Vedanta is often paired with Purva Mimamsa, as they are both based on the Vedas .

These are the six systems of Indian philosophy, each with its own distinctive features and contributions to the intellectual and spiritual heritage of India. They are not mutually exclusive, but rather complementary and interrelated, as they address different aspects of reality and knowledge. They also influence and interact with each

### Shankaracharya and Advaita Vedanta

- Shankaracharya, also known as Adi Shankara, was an Indian philosopher and theologian who expounded the doctrine of Advaita Vedanta, one of the six orthodox schools of Hindu philosophy .
- Advaita Vedanta is a non-dualistic system of thought that asserts the identity of the individual self (atman) and the supreme reality (brahman), and denies the existence of any independent reality other than brahman.
- Shankaracharya was born in a Brahmin family in Kaladi, Kerala, around

the 8th century CE. He renounced the worldly life at a very young age and became a wandering ascetic. He studied under various teachers, including Govinda Bhagavatpada, who initiated him into the Advaita Vedanta tradition .

- Shankaracharya wrote commentaries on the Upanishads, the Brahma Sutras, and the Bhagavad Gita, which are considered the foundational texts of Advaita Vedanta. He also composed original works, such as the Vivekachudamani, the Upadesasahasri, and the Crest-Jewel of Discrimination, which explain the main tenets of his philosophy .
- Shankaracharya established four monastic centers (mathas) in the four corners of India, namely Sringeri in the south, Dwarka in the west, Puri in the east, and Badrinath in the north. He appointed four of his disciples as the heads of these mathas, who continued his lineage and teachings. He also debated and defeated various rival schools of thought, such as Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa, and Nyaya .
- Shankaracharya is regarded as one of the most influential and revered figures in Hinduism, especially by the followers of Advaita Vedanta. He is credited with reviving and reforming the Vedic tradition, and reconciling the various sects and schools of Hinduism. He is also considered a great poet, mystic, and devotee, who composed many hymns and songs in praise of various deities .
- The cultural influence of Shankara and Advaita Vedanta started only centuries later, in the Vijayanagara Empire in the 14th century, when Sringeri matha started to receive patronage from the kings of the Vijayanagara Empire and became a powerful institution. Advaita Vedanta also influenced the Bhakti movement, the Sikh religion, and the modern Hindu reform movements.
- Advaita Vedanta remains one of the most popular and influential schools of Hindu philosophy today, with many contemporary teachers and followers. It also has attracted the interest of Western scholars and philosophers, who have compared and contrasted it with other systems of thought, such as Platonism, Kantianism, and Phenomenology .

### **Various Philosophical Doctrines in India**

- Indian philosophy refers to the systems of thought and reflection that were developed by the civilizations of the Indian subcontinent.
- Indian philosophy is characterized by its diversity, continuity, synthesis, and spiritual orientation .
- Indian philosophy accepts the authority of ancient philosophers and innovations are represented as extensions of older systems of thought.
- Indian philosophy shares many common themes such as the self or soul (atman), works (karma), liberation (moksha), and the cycle of birth and death (samsara).
- Indian philosophy can be broadly divided into two categories: orthodox (astika) and unorthodox (nastika) .

- Orthodox schools accept the authority of the Vedas, the ancient scriptures of Hinduism, while unorthodox schools reject or question the Vedas .
- The six orthodox schools of Indian philosophy are: Sankhya, Yoga, Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa, and Vedanta .
- Sankhya is a dualistic system that posits two independent realities: purusha (consciousness) and prakriti (matter).
- Yoga is a system that is similar to Sankhya but accepts a personal god and focuses on yogic practices for attaining liberation.
- Nyaya is a system that emphasizes logic and epistemology as the means of acquiring valid knowledge.
- Vaisheshika is a system that analyzes reality into six categories: substance, quality, action, universality, particularity, and inherence.
- Mimamsa is a system that interprets the Vedas and the rituals prescribed in them as the means of achieving happiness and liberation.
- Vedanta is a system that expounds the metaphysical and ethical teachings of the Upanishads, the philosophical portions of the Vedas.
- The three unorthodox schools of Indian philosophy are: Buddhism, Jainism, and Charvaka .
- Buddhism is a system that rejects the notion of a permanent self and teaches the four noble truths and the eightfold path as the way to end suffering and attain nirvana.
- Jainism is a system that emphasizes non-violence, asceticism, and the multiplicity of viewpoints as the means of achieving liberation from karma and samsara.
- Charvaka is a system that denies the existence of anything beyond the material world and advocates hedonism and skepticism as the only rational way of life.

### Heterodox Sects in India

- Heterodox sects are those that do not accept the authority of the Vedas, the sacred scriptures of Hinduism, and challenge the orthodox Brahmanical traditions and rituals.
- Heterodox sects emerged in the 6th century BCE as part of the Sramana movement, which was a cultural and religious phenomenon that advocated renunciation, asceticism, and liberation from the cycle of rebirth.
- Some of the prominent heterodox sects in India are:
  - Jainism: Founded by Mahavira, the 24th Tirthankara, Jainism teaches the doctrine of ahimsa (non-violence), anekantavada (many-sidedness of truth), and aparigraha (non-attachment). Jainism rejects the concept of a creator god and believes in the existence of jivas (souls) and ajivas (non-souls) that are bound by karma and can attain moksha (liberation) by following the five vows of conduct.
  - Buddhism: Founded by Siddhartha Gautama, the Buddha, Buddhism teaches the four noble truths, the eightfold path, and the concept of nirvana (extinction of suffering). Buddhism rejects the

authority of the Vedas, the caste system, and the ritual sacrifices. Buddhism also denies the existence of a permanent self or soul and advocates the doctrine of anatman (no-self) and pratityasamutpada (dependent origination).

- Ajivika: Founded by Makkhali Gosala, Ajivika is a materialist and fatalist sect that believes in the doctrine of niyati (determinism) and the inevitability of the cycle of rebirth. Ajivika denies the existence of free will, moral responsibility, and the efficacy of human action. Ajivika also rejects the concept of a god, karma, and liberation.
- Carvaka: Also known as Lokayata, Carvaka is a radical materialist and atheist sect that believes in the doctrine of svabhava (nature) and the primacy of the four elements (earth, water, fire, and air). Carvaka denies the existence of anything beyond the material world, such as the soul, the afterlife, the Vedas, the gods, and the supernatural. Carvaka also advocates the pursuit of sensual pleasure and happiness in this life.

### **Bhakti Movement in India**

- The Bhakti movement was a significant religious movement in medieval Hinduism that sought to bring religious reforms to all strata of society by adopting the method of devotion to achieve salvation.
- The movement preached against the caste system, ritualism, idolatry, and social inequalities, and emphasized the personal and emotional relationship between the devotee and the deity .
- The movement originated in South India in the 7th-8th centuries CE with the Alvars (Vaishnavite saints) and the Nayanars (Shaivite saints), who composed devotional hymns in Tamil and visited various sacred shrines .
- The movement spread to North India in the 12th-13th centuries CE with the influence of the Bhakti saints like Ramananda, Kabir, Nanak, Tulsidas, Surdas, Mirabai, and Chaitanya, who propagated their teachings in the regional languages like Hindi, Punjabi, Bengali, and Marathi .
- The movement had a profound impact on the Indian society, culture, and literature. It fostered a spirit of tolerance, harmony, and universal brotherhood among the people of different faiths and sects. It also enriched the Indian languages and literature with a vast corpus of devotional poetry, songs, and stories .

### **Sufi movement in India**

- Sufism is a mystical branch of Islam that emphasizes the personal and spiritual experience of God.
- Sufism originated in the Middle East in the 8th and 9th centuries and spread to various regions, including India, through the travels and teachings of Sufi saints or sheikhs.
- Sufism in India began in the 13th century with the arrival of the Chishti

order, founded by Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti, who settled in Ajmer and preached a message of love, tolerance and service to humanity.

- Sufism in India developed into various orders or silsilas, such as the Chishti, Suhrawardi, Qadiri, Naqshbandi, Shattari and others, each with its own doctrines, rituals and practices.
- Sufism in India attracted people from different backgrounds, religions and castes, as it offered a direct and personal connection with God, without the mediation of priests or rituals.
- Sufism in India also influenced the development of the Bhakti movement, a devotional movement that emerged in the 15th and 16th centuries and emphasized the worship of one God through love, devotion and surrender.
- Sufism in India contributed to the cultural, social and artistic life of the country, as Sufi saints composed poetry, music, literature and art that expressed their mystical experiences and teachings.
- Sufism in India also played a role in the political and historical events of the country, as some Sufi saints supported or opposed the rulers of the Delhi Sultanate, the Mughal Empire and the British Raj.
- Sufism in India continues to exist today as a living tradition that attracts followers from various walks of life and promotes the values of peace, harmony and pluralism.

### **Socio religious reform movement of 19th century in India**

- Socio religious reform movement of 19th century in India refers to the wave of reforming activities that aimed to reform the Indian society and religion in the light of western education and liberal ideas.
- The main causes of the reform movement were:
  - The impact of British colonialism and western culture on the Indian society, which exposed the evils and superstitions of the traditional social and religious practices.
  - The rise of modern education, science, rationalism, humanism and democracy, which challenged the authority of the orthodox and conservative elements.
  - The influence of the Christian missionaries, who criticized the Hindu religion and tried to convert the Indians to Christianity.
  - The emergence of a new class of educated and enlightened Indians, who felt the need to reform their society and religion from within.
- The main types of the reform movement were:
  - The Hindu reform movements, such as the Brahmo Samaj, the Arya Samaj, the Prarthana Samaj, the Ramakrishna Mission, the Theosophical Society, etc., which aimed to reform the Hindu religion and society by removing the evils of casteism, idolatry, polytheism, rituals, superstitions, etc., and promoting the ideals of monotheism, rationalism, social equality, women's education, etc. .
  - The Muslim reform movements, such as the Aligarh movement, the Deoband movement, the Wahabi movement, the Ahmadiyya move-

- ment, etc., which aimed to reform the Muslim religion and society by removing the degeneration and corruption of the Islamic faith and culture, and promoting the ideals of modern education, social reform, religious revival, etc. .
- The Sikh reform movements, such as the Singh Sabha movement, the Akali movement, the Nirankari movement, etc., which aimed to reform the Sikh religion and society by removing the influence of Hinduism and Islam on the Sikh faith and culture, and promoting the ideals of Khalsa identity, Sikh unity, religious purity, etc..
- The Parsi reform movements, such as the Rehnumai Mazdayasan Sabha, the Parsi Pragati Mandal, the Parsi Panchayat, etc., which aimed to reform the Parsi religion and society by removing the rigid and orthodox practices of the Parsi faith and culture, and promoting the ideals of social reform, religious tolerance, women's rights, etc..
- The main impacts of the reform movement were:
  - The reform movement contributed to the awakening of the Indian people and the growth of Indian nationalism, as it fostered a sense of pride and self-respect among the Indians and challenged the colonial domination and exploitation .
  - The reform movement stimulated the social and religious changes in the Indian society, as it led to the abolition or reform of some of the social evils and religious practices, such as sati, child marriage, widow remarriage, untouchability, etc., and the promotion of some of the social and religious values, such as education, equality, human rights, etc. .
  - The reform movement also faced some limitations and challenges, such as the resistance from the orthodox and conservative sections of the society, the lack of mass participation and support, the emergence of communalism and sectarianism, the diversity and complexity of the Indian society and culture, etc. .

### **Modern religious practices in India**

- India is a secular country with a diverse population that follows various religions, such as Hinduism, Islam, Christianity, Sikhism, Buddhism, Jainism, Zoroastrianism, and others .
- Religion has a significant influence on the culture, politics, and economy of India, and many Indians take pride in their rich religious heritage.
- Hinduism is the dominant religion in India, with about 80% of the population identifying as Hindu. Hinduism is a complex and diverse faith that encompasses many sects, schools, and traditions. Some of the common practices of Hinduism include worshiping various gods and goddesses, performing rituals and ceremonies, celebrating festivals, practicing yoga and meditation, and following ethical principles .
- Islam is the second-largest religion in India, with about 14% of the population identifying as Muslim. Islam is a monotheistic religion that follows

the teachings of the Quran and the Prophet Muhammad. Some of the common practices of Islam include praying five times a day, fasting during Ramadan, giving alms to the poor, performing pilgrimage to Mecca, and observing dietary and dress codes .

- Christianity is the third-largest religion in India, with about 2% of the population identifying as Christian. Christianity is a monotheistic religion that follows the teachings of Jesus Christ and the Bible. Some of the common practices of Christianity include attending church services, celebrating festivals such as Christmas and Easter, reading and studying the Bible, and following the commandments of God .
- Sikhism is the fourth-largest religion in India, with about 2% of the population identifying as Sikh. Sikhism is a monotheistic religion that follows the teachings of the Guru Granth Sahib and the ten Gurus. Some of the common practices of Sikhism include wearing the five Ks (articles of faith), reciting the daily prayers, visiting the gurdwara (place of worship), and serving the community .
- Buddhism is the fifth-largest religion in India, with about 1% of the population identifying as Buddhist. Buddhism is a non-theistic religion that follows the teachings of the Buddha and the Dharma. Some of the common practices of Buddhism include following the Noble Eightfold Path, meditating, chanting, observing the precepts, and venerating the Buddha and other enlightened beings .
- Jainism is the sixth-largest religion in India, with about 0.4% of the population identifying as Jain. Jainism is a non-theistic religion that follows the teachings of the Tirthankaras (spiritual teachers) and the Jain Agamas (scriptures). Some of the common practices of Jainism include practicing non-violence, truthfulness, non-stealing, chastity, and non-attachment, performing rituals and ceremonies, observing fasting and festivals, and respecting all living beings .
- Zoroastrianism is a minority religion in India, with a few thousand adherents, mostly belonging to the Parsi community. Zoroastrianism is a monotheistic religion that follows the teachings of Zoroaster and the Avesta (sacred texts). Some of the common practices of Zoroastrianism include worshiping Ahura Mazda (the supreme god), performing rituals and ceremonies, observing ethical and moral values, and disposing of the dead through the Tower of Silence .
- Apart from these major religions, there are also some indigenous and tribal religions practiced in India, such as Sanamahism, Animism, Sarnaism, and others. These religions are often based on the worship of nature, ancestors, spirits, and local deities, and have their own customs and traditions .
- India's religious groups share several religious practices and beliefs, such as belief in reincarnation, karma, dharma, and the cycle of birth and death, respect for elders and teachers, reverence for cows and other animals, and celebration of common festivals and occasions. However, there are also differences and conflicts among the religious groups, such as over caste, conversion, cow slaughter, communal violence, and personal laws .

## Module 4-Science, Management and Indian Knowledge System

This module covers the following topics:

- **Astronomy in India:** The ancient Indian astronomers made significant contributions to the fields of observational astronomy, mathematical astronomy, cosmology, calendar systems, and astrology. Some of the notable astronomers include Aryabhata, Varahamihira, Brahmagupta, Bhaskara, and Lalla. They developed concepts such as the heliocentric model, the lunar and solar eclipses, the precession of the equinoxes, the calculation of the sidereal year, the value of pi, and the use of trigonometric functions .
- **Chemistry in India:** The ancient Indian chemists were adept at the extraction, purification, and synthesis of various metals, minerals, dyes, drugs, and perfumes. They also developed techniques such as distillation, sublimation, calcination, and fermentation. Some of the notable chemists include Nagarjuna, Kanada, Charaka, Sushruta, and Patanjali. They developed concepts such as the atomic theory, the classification of elements, the theory of combustion, the medicinal properties of plants and minerals, and the preparation of various compounds .
- **Mathematics in India:** The ancient Indian mathematicians made remarkable advances in the fields of arithmetic, algebra, geometry, trigonometry, calculus, and combinatorics. Some of the notable mathematicians include Baudhayana, Apastamba, Pingala, Panini, Katyayana, Aryabhata, Brahmagupta, Bhaskara, Mahavira, and Madhava. They developed concepts such as the decimal system, the zero, the negative numbers, the square root, the quadratic equation, the Pythagorean theorem, the sine and cosine functions, the infinite series, and the binomial theorem .
- **Physics in India:** The ancient Indian physicists were interested in the nature of matter, energy, motion, sound, light, and gravity. Some of the notable physicists include Kanada, Kapila, Patanjali, Bharata, Varahamihira, Aryabhata, and Bhaskara. They developed concepts such as the five elements, the three gunas, the prana, the yoga, the theory of relativity, the law of conservation of mass, the Doppler effect, the refraction of light, and the gravitational attraction .
- **Agriculture in India:** The ancient Indian agriculturists were skilled in the cultivation, irrigation, and harvesting of various crops, fruits, vegetables, and spices. They also practiced animal husbandry, beekeeping, and silk production. Some of the notable agriculturists include Kashyapa, Parashara, Varahamihira, Surapala, and Someshvara. They developed concepts such as the crop rotation, the soil fertility, the pest control, the water management, the grafting, and the hybridization .
- **Medicine in India:** The ancient Indian physicians were proficient in the diagnosis, treatment, and prevention of various diseases, injuries, and disorders. They also practiced surgery, dentistry, ophthalmology, and psychology. Some of the notable physicians include Charaka, Sushruta, Vagbhata,



Nagarjuna, and Madhava. They developed concepts such as the Ayurveda, the four humors, the six tastes, the eight branches, the pulse diagnosis, the anesthesia, the plastic surgery, and the cataract surgery .

- Metallurgy in India: The ancient Indian metallurgists were expert in the production, processing, and usage of various metals and alloys, such as iron, steel, copper, bronze, brass, zinc, tin, lead, gold, and silver. They also invented tools, weapons, ornaments, coins, and sculptures. Some of the notable metallurgists include Nagarjuna, Dharmottara, Bhoja, and Someshvara. They developed concepts such as the wootz steel, the iron pillar, the zinc distillation, the coinage, and the lost-wax casting .
- Geography in India: The ancient Indian geographers were curious about the shape, size, and features of the earth, the continents, the oceans, the rivers

### **Astronomy in India and Ancient India**

- Astronomy in India has a long history stretching from pre-historic to modern times. Some of the earliest roots of Indian astronomy can be dated to the period of Indus Valley civilisation or earlier.
- Astronomy in ancient India developed to a sophisticated level as the sages of ancient India were keen observers of the sky generation after generation. They recorded their observations and calculations in various texts, such as the Vedas, the Puranas, the Siddhantas, the Aryabhatiya, the Surya Siddhanta, and the Brihat Samhita.
- Astronomy in ancient India can be divided into two major classes. From the third-century BCE, India started having contact with Greece and other nations outside the subcontinent. So, the basic structure of Indian astronomy had outside influence although the astronomical concepts and the major parameters were India's own.
- The first class of Indian astronomy is called Vedanga Jyotisha, which is based on the Vedas and deals with the calendrical and ritual aspects of astronomy. The second class is called Siddhantic astronomy, which is based on the Siddhantas and deals with the mathematical and predictive aspects of astronomy.
- Some of the notable achievements of ancient Indian astronomers include:
  - The concept of zero and the decimal system of numeration.
  - The accurate determination of the length of the solar year, the lunar month, the sidereal day, and the precession of the equinoxes.
  - The discovery of the heliocentric model of the solar system by Aryabhata in the 5th century CE.
  - The calculation of the value of pi and the circumference of the earth by Aryabhata.
  - The use of trigonometric functions and algebraic methods to solve astronomical problems.
  - The invention of the sine table by Aryabhata and its improvement by Bhaskara II.

- The formulation of the law of gravity by Brahmagupta in the 7th century CE.
- The development of various astronomical instruments, such as the gnomon, the water clock, the armillary sphere, and the astrolabe.
- The observation and explanation of various astronomical phenomena, such as eclipses, comets, meteors, planets, stars, and constellations.
- The classification of the stars into 27 nakshatras or lunar mansions and 12 rasis or zodiac signs.
- The creation of various astrological systems, such as horoscopy, natal astrology, electional astrology, and mundane astrology.
- Astronomy in ancient India had a profound and direct influence on the astronomy of other cultures, such as Islamic, Byzantine, Chinese, and Tibetan astronomy . Indian astronomy also contributed to the fields of mathematics, medicine, art, literature, and philosophy.

### Chemistry in India and Ancient India

- Chemistry in ancient India was called **Rasayana** in Sanskrit, which means **extract** or **essence** of substances .
- Chemistry in ancient India was not confined to theoretical aspects, but found development in various practical activities, such as metallurgy, medicine, alchemy, cosmetics, perfumery, dyeing, agriculture, and warfare .
- Some of the achievements of chemistry in ancient India are:
  - The discovery and extraction of metals, such as gold, silver, copper, iron, zinc, tin, and lead, from their ores, and the production of alloys, such as brass, bronze, and steel .
  - The development of Ayurveda, the system of medicine that uses natural substances, such as herbs, minerals, and animal products, for diagnosis and treatment of diseases .
  - The invention of various chemical processes, such as distillation, calcination, sublimation, fermentation, and extraction, and the use of various apparatus, such as crucibles, retorts, alembics, and furnaces, for conducting chemical experiments .
  - The preparation of various chemical substances, such as acids, alkalis, salts, mercury, sulfur, arsenic, and borax, and their applications in medicine, alchemy, cosmetics, perfumery, dyeing, and warfare .
  - The development of alchemy, the art of transforming base metals into gold or silver, and the search for the elixir of life, which was believed to confer immortality .
- Some of the prominent chemists in ancient India are:
  - Nagarjuna (c. 8th century CE), who wrote the **Rasaratnakara**, a treatise on alchemy, metallurgy, and medicine, and who is credited with the discovery of zinc and its extraction by distillation .
  - Kanada (c. 6th century BCE), who wrote the **Vaisheshika Sutra**, a philosophical text that postulated the atomic theory of matter and

the classification of substances into six categories: earth, water, fire, air, ether, and time .

- Charaka (c. 2nd century CE), who wrote the **Charaka Samhita**, a compendium of Ayurvedic medicine, and who described the properties and uses of various drugs, such as opium, mercury, sulfur, and arsenic .
- Patanjali (c. 2nd century BCE), who wrote the **Yoga Sutra**, a text on the philosophy and practice of yoga, and who mentioned the use of mercury and sulfur for attaining physical and mental perfection .
- Varahamihira (c. 6th century CE), who wrote the **Brihat Samhita**, an encyclopedic work on astronomy, astrology, geography, and meteorology, and who gave the methods of preparing various chemical substances, such as acids, alkalis, salts, and dyes .

### Mathematics in India and Ancient India

- Mathematics or ‘Ganita’ was the ‘Science of Calculations’ in ancient India.
- Mathematics was considered as one of the highest sciences and the head of all Vedas and shastras.
- The origin of ancient mathematics can be traced to the Indus valley civilization, which had a sophisticated system of weights and measures, geometry, and decimal notation.
- The classical period of Indian mathematics (400 CE to 1200 CE) saw important contributions by scholars like Aryabhata, Brahmagupta, Bhaskara II, and Varāhamihira .
- Some of the achievements of Indian mathematics include:
  - The concept of zero and its use as a placeholder and a number .
  - The decimal place-value system and the use of symbols for digits .
  - The development of algebra, including quadratic equations, indeterminate equations, and the concept of negative numbers .
  - The development of trigonometry, including the sine, cosine, and tangent functions, and the use of the Pythagorean theorem .
  - The development of arithmetic, including fractions, square roots, and the concept of infinity .
  - The development of geometry, including the approximation of pi, the area of a circle, and the volume of a sphere .
  - The development of astronomy, including the calculation of the solar and lunar eclipses, the heliocentric model of the solar system, and the sidereal year .
- Indian mathematics influenced the mathematics of other civilizations, such as the Arabs, the Greeks, the Chinese, and the Europeans .

### Physics in India and Ancient India

- Physics is the branch of science that deals with the nature and properties of matter and energy, and the interactions between them.

- Physics in India has a long and rich history, dating back to the ancient times, when Indian philosophers and sages developed various systems of thought and knowledge that explored the physical world and its phenomena.
- Some of the main achievements and contributions of physics in India and ancient India are:
  - The concept of **atomism**, which is the idea that all matter is composed of indivisible and indestructible units called atoms. This concept was first proposed by **Maharishi Kanada** around 200 BCE, and later elaborated by **Dharmakirti** and **Dignaga** in the 1st millennium CE .
  - The theory of **elements**, which is the idea that there are five basic elements that constitute the universe: earth, water, fire, air, and ether. This theory was developed by various schools of Indian philosophy, such as **Nyaya**, **Vaisheshika**, **Samkhya**, and **Yoga**.
  - The understanding of **energy** and its equivalence to mass, as well as the nature of **heat** and **light** radiation. These aspects were discussed by **Kanada**, **Dignaga**, **Bharadwaja**, and **Sayanacharya** in the Vedic era, and later confirmed by modern physics.
  - The recognition of the **wave-particle duality** of light and matter, which is the idea that both light and matter can exhibit both wave-like and particle-like behavior. This concept was suggested by **Kanada** and **Dignaga**, and later verified by quantum mechanics.
  - The development of **astronomy** and **mathematics**, which are essential for the advancement of physics. Indian astronomers and mathematicians, such as **Aryabhata**, **Brahmagupta**, **Bhaskara**, **Varahamihira**, and **Madhava**, made significant discoveries and inventions in these fields, such as the concept of zero, the decimal system, the heliocentric model, the calculation of pi, the trigonometric functions, and the infinite series.

## Agriculture in India and Ancient India

- Agriculture is one of the oldest and most important activities in human history. It involves the cultivation of plants and animals for food, fiber, fuel, medicine and other products.
- India has a rich and diverse agricultural heritage that dates back to the prehistoric times. India is one of the world's largest producers and consumers of agricultural products, and has a significant role in global food security and trade.
- Agriculture in India and Ancient India can be studied under various aspects, such as:
  - **Geographical regions and climatic conditions:** India has a vast

and varied geography, ranging from the Himalayan mountains to the coastal plains, from the Thar desert to the tropical forests. The climate of India is also diverse, with four seasons: winter, summer, monsoon and post-monsoon. These factors influence the types and distribution of crops and animals in different regions of India.

- **Historical periods and cultural influences:** India has a long and complex history, marked by the rise and fall of various civilizations, empires, kingdoms and dynasties. Each period had its own impact on the development and diffusion of agricultural practices, technologies, innovations and institutions. Some of the major historical periods and cultural influences on Indian agriculture are:

- \* **Indus Valley Civilization (c. 2500-1900 BCE):** This was one of the earliest urban civilizations in the world, located in the north-western part of India and Pakistan. The Indus people cultivated wheat, barley, rice, millets, peas, lentils, sesame, cotton and dates, and domesticated cattle, sheep, goats, pigs and dogs. They also developed irrigation systems, ploughs, granaries, weights and measures, and trade networks.
- \* **Vedic Period (c. 1500-500 BCE):** This was the period of the composition of the Vedas, the oldest scriptures of Hinduism. The Vedic people were mostly pastoralists, who migrated from Central Asia to the Indo-Gangetic plains. They worshipped fire, sun, rain and other natural forces, and performed rituals and sacrifices for the prosperity of their crops and animals. They cultivated rice, barley, millets, pulses, oilseeds, sugarcane and fruits, and domesticated horses, cows, bulls, elephants and camels. They also introduced iron tools, ploughs, wells and canals.
- \* **Mauryan Empire (c. 321-185 BCE):** This was the first pan-Indian empire, founded by Chandragupta Maurya and expanded by Ashoka. The Mauryans consolidated the political and economic unity of India, and promoted agriculture, trade and commerce. They cultivated wheat, rice, barley, millets, pulses, oilseeds, cotton, indigo, spices and fruits, and domesticated cattle, sheep, goats, pigs, horses, elephants and camels. They also developed irrigation systems, roads, bridges, ports, granaries, taxes and coinage.
- \* **Gupta Empire (c. 320-550 CE):** This was the golden age of Indian culture, science, art and literature, under the rule of the Gupta dynasty. The Guptas fostered a peaceful and prosperous society, and patronized agriculture, trade and education. They cultivated wheat, rice, barley, millets, pulses, oilseeds, cotton, sugarcane, spices and fruits, and domesticated cattle, sheep, goats, pigs, horses, elephants and camels. They also improved irrigation systems, ploughs, wells, canals, dams, reservoirs, tanks and ponds.

- \* **Medieval Period (c. 600-1500 CE):** This was the period of the invasion and rule of various foreign dynasties, such as the Huns, Arabs, Turks, Mongols, Afghans and Mughals. The medieval period witnessed the introduction and diffusion of new crops, animals, technologies and institutions in Indian agriculture, as well as the conflicts and interactions between different religions, cultures and regions. Some of the new crops and animals introduced in this period were rice, wheat, barley, millets, pulses, oilseeds, cotton, sugarcane, spices, fruits, vegetables, flowers, tea, coffee, tobacco, opium, silk, saffron, horses, camels, donkeys, mules, yaks, buffaloes, chickens, ducks, geese and turkeys. Some of the new technologies and institutions introduced in this period were irrigation systems, canals, dams, reservoirs

### Medicine in India and Ancient India

- Medicine in India is a diverse and ancient field of knowledge and practice that encompasses various systems of health care, such as Ayurveda, Siddha, Unani, Yoga, Naturopathy, and Homeopathy.
- Ayurveda is the most ancient system of Indian medicine, which is based on the concept of balance among the five elements (earth, water, fire, air, and ether) and the three doshas (vata, pitta, and kapha) that govern the body and mind .
- Ayurveda originated in the Vedic period, when Indians attained a high degree of knowledge and wisdom in medicine, surgery, materia medica, and chemistry . Ayurveda is considered a holistic and natural approach to physical and mental health, and it uses various methods such as diet, herbs, massage, meditation, and purification to prevent and treat diseases.
- Some of the famous ancient Indian physicians and surgeons were Charaka, Sushruta, Vagbhata, Nagarjuna, and Dhanvantari . They wrote authoritative texts on various aspects of medicine and surgery, such as the Charaka Samhita, the Sushruta Samhita, the Ashtanga Hridaya, the Sushruta Tantra, and the Sushruta Nidana .
- These texts describe various diseases, symptoms, diagnoses, treatments, surgical procedures, instruments, and anatomical knowledge in detail. Some of the remarkable achievements of ancient Indian medicine and surgery include plastic surgery, cataract surgery, rhinoplasty, lithotomy, caesarean section, anesthesia, and vaccination .
- Medicine in India has evolved over time and has been influenced by various factors, such as religion, culture, geography, and foreign invasions. India has also contributed to the development of medicine in other parts of the world, such as China, Tibet, Persia, Arabia, and Europe.
- Today, medicine in India is a blend of modern and traditional systems, and it offers a wide range of options and opportunities for health care seekers and providers. India is also a hub of medical tourism, research, and innovation in the field of medicine.

## Metallurgy in India and Ancient India

Metallurgy is the science and art of extracting and processing metals from ores and other sources. Metallurgy in India and ancient India has a long and rich history, dating back to the prehistoric times. Some of the main aspects of metallurgy in India and ancient India are:

- **Copper metallurgy:** Copper was one of the first metals to be used by humans, and copper metallurgy in India dates back to the Chalcolithic societies in the subcontinent, around the 4th millennium BCE. Copper was used for making tools, weapons, ornaments, coins, and other objects. Copper was also alloyed with tin to produce bronze, which was harder and more durable than pure copper. The Harappan civilization (2500-1900 BCE) was known for its advanced copper and bronze metallurgy, as evidenced by the artefacts found at various sites, such as Mitathal in Haryana.
- **Iron metallurgy:** Iron is the most widely used metal in the world, and iron metallurgy in India has a long and distinguished history, starting from the early Vedic period (1500-500 BCE). Iron was mentioned in various Vedic texts, such as the Rigveda, the Atharvaveda, and the Yajurveda, as a symbol of strength, power, and wealth. Iron was used for making weapons, tools, agricultural implements, and other items. Iron was also smelted and forged into steel, which was superior to iron in terms of hardness, toughness, and resistance to corrosion. Ancient Indians were masters in the production of iron and steel, and developed various methods of extraction, classification, and microstructural analysis of iron and steel. Some of the famous examples of ancient Indian iron and steel are the iron pillar of Delhi (4th century CE), the wootz steel (6th century BCE onwards), and the Damascus steel (11th century CE onwards).
- **Zinc metallurgy:** Zinc is a metal that is essential for various biological and industrial processes, and zinc metallurgy in India is one of the oldest and most sophisticated in the world. Zinc was extracted in India as early as in the 4th to 3rd century BCE, using a distillation technique that was developed at Zawar in Rajasthan. Zinc was used for making brass (an alloy of copper and zinc), coins, medicine, cosmetics, and other products. Zinc was also exported to other countries, such as China, Europe, and the Middle East, where it was highly valued for its properties and applications.
- **Other metals:** Apart from copper, iron, and zinc, ancient Indians also knew and used various other metals, such as gold, silver, lead, tin, mercury, and arsenic. These metals were mentioned in various ancient texts, such as the Vedas, the Arthashastra, the Rasaratnakara, and the Charaka Samhita, and were used for various purposes, such as jewellery, coinage, medicine, alchemy, and metallurgical experiments. Ancient Indians also developed various methods of testing, purifying, and alloying metals, and were aware of the properties and effects of different metals and their combinations.

## Geography in India and Ancient India

- India is a large country in South Asia, with a total area of 3.28 million square kilometers. It is the seventh-largest country in the world by area and the second-most populous country with over 1.3 billion people.
- India has a diverse geography, with various landforms such as mountains, plains, plateaus, deserts, coasts, and islands. It is also home to many rivers, lakes, forests, and wildlife.
- India is situated on the Indian Plate, a major tectonic plate that was formed when it split off from the ancient continent of Gondwana. The Indian Plate is moving northward and colliding with the Eurasian Plate, creating the Himalayan Mountains and the Tibetan Plateau.
- In ancient times, the geography of India was a little different than what it is today. The northern part of India was dominated by the Himalayan Mountains and the Hindu Kush Mountains, which acted as natural barriers for invaders and nomads. The southern part of India was surrounded by three bodies of water: the Arabian Sea, the Indian Ocean, and the Bay of Bengal.
- The geography of India influenced the development of various civilizations and cultures in ancient times. The Indus Valley Civilization (2500-1900 BCE) was one of the earliest urban civilizations in the world, which flourished along the Indus River and its tributaries in present-day Pakistan and northwest India. The Indus Valley Civilization had a sophisticated urban planning, sanitation, trade, and writing system.
- The Aryan Civilization (1500-500 BCE) was another ancient civilization that emerged in India, which was based on the migration of Indo-European speaking nomads from Central Asia. The Aryans settled in the Gangetic Plain and introduced the Vedic culture, which was based on the Vedas, the oldest scriptures of Hinduism. The Aryans also developed the caste system, the four varnas (social classes), and the concept of karma and reincarnation.
- The Mauryan Empire (322-185 BCE) was the first pan-Indian empire, which was founded by Chandragupta Maurya after he defeated the Nanda Dynasty and the Greek invaders. The Mauryan Empire reached its peak under Ashoka, who ruled from 268 to 232 BCE. Ashoka was a great conqueror and a patron of Buddhism, who spread his message of peace and tolerance through his edicts and pillars across India and beyond.
- The Gupta Empire (320-550 CE) was another great empire in ancient India, which is considered the Golden Age of Indian history. The Gupta Empire was founded by Chandragupta I, who consolidated his power by marrying the daughter of the Licchavi king. The Gupta Empire was known for its achievements in art, literature, science, mathematics, astronomy, medicine, and architecture. The Gupta Empire also promoted Hinduism and Sanskrit as the official language and culture.



## Biology in India and Ancient India

- Biology is the study of life and living organisms, including their structure, function, evolution, and interactions with the environment.
- India has a rich and diverse biological heritage, dating back to ancient times, when the people of the Indian subcontinent had a well-developed science of agriculture, medicine, and natural history.
- Some of the main sources of information about biology in ancient India are the Vedas, the ancient scriptures of Hinduism, which contain hymns, rituals, and cosmology, as well as observations of plants and animals.
- According to the Vedas, there are 740 plants and 250 animals recorded, proving that in the Vedic period (3000-800 BCE), observations of plants and animals were carried out and recorded .
- The Vedas also mention the concept of prana, the vital force or life energy that pervades all living beings, and the five elements (earth, water, fire, air, and ether) that constitute the material world.
- The Vedas also classify living beings into four categories: jarayuja (born from the womb), andaja (born from eggs), svedaja (born from sweat), and udbhijja (born from the soil).
- Another source of information about biology in ancient India is the archaeological evidence, such as the ruins of Mohenjo-daro, one of the oldest urban civilizations in the world, dating back to 2500 BCE.
- The ruins of Mohenjo-daro have yielded seeds of wheat and barley that were cultivated at that time, as well as millet, dates, melons, and other fruits and vegetables, and cotton.
- The people of Mohenjo-daro also had knowledge of animal husbandry, as evidenced by the remains of cattle, sheep, goats, pigs, dogs, and elephants.
- The people of Mohenjo-daro also practiced dentistry, as evidenced by the discovery of a drilled molar tooth, which is one of the earliest examples of dental surgery in the world.
- Another source of information about biology in ancient India is the literature of the classical period (500 BCE-500 CE), such as the epics, the Puranas, the Buddhist and Jain texts, and the works of grammar, philosophy, and medicine.
- The epics, such as the Ramayana and the Mahabharata, contain descriptions of various plants and animals, such as the ashoka tree, the lotus flower, the peacock, the monkey, and the elephant, as well as mythical creatures, such as the garuda, the naga, and the rakshasa.
- The Puranas, which are ancient stories of gods and goddesses, also contain references to plants and animals, such as the kalpavriksha, the wish-fulfilling tree, the kamadhenu, the cow of plenty, and the shalabha, the grasshopper.
- The Buddhist and Jain texts, which are the scriptures of the two major non-Vedic religions of ancient India, also contain information about biology, such as the concept of rebirth, the doctrine of ahimsa, or non-violence towards all living beings, and the classification of living beings

into six realms: gods, demi-gods, humans, animals, hungry ghosts, and hell beings.

- The works of grammar, such as the Ashtadhyayi of Panini, the oldest surviving grammar of Sanskrit, also contain information about biology, such as the names and categories of plants and animals, and the rules of word formation and derivation.
- The works of philosophy, such as the Nyaya, the Vaisheshika, the Samkhya, the Yoga, the Mimamsa, and the Vedanta, also contain information about biology, such as the concepts of atman, the self or soul, and brahman, the supreme reality, the theory of causation, the theory of perception, and the theory of evolution.
- The works of medicine, such as the Charaka Samhita and the Sushruta Samhita, the two main texts of Ayurveda, the ancient system of medicine and healing, also contain information about biology, such as the concepts of dosha, the three bodily humors, and dhatu, the seven bodily tissues, the anatomy and physiology of the human body, the diagnosis and treatment of diseases, and the methods of surgery and anesthesia.
- The works of medicine also contain information about botany, such as the names and properties of hundreds

### Harappan Technologies in India and Ancient India

- The Harappan Civilization, also known as the Indus Valley Civilization, was one of the earliest urban cultures of the Indian subcontinent, dating from 3300 to 1300 BCE .
- The Harappans developed various technologies and innovations in various fields, such as:
  - **Metallurgy:** The Harappans used copper, bronze, lead, and tin to make tools, weapons, ornaments, and seals. They also knew how to smelt iron, but did not use it extensively .
  - **Standardized weights and measures:** The Harappans used a system of uniform weights and measures based on a decimal scale. They also used a ruler with markings of 1.32 inches, which corresponds to one Indus inch .
  - **Seal carving:** The Harappans carved seals out of steatite, a soft stone, and engraved them with various motifs, such as animals, plants, and symbols. The seals were used for trade, administration, and ritual purposes. Some of the seals also have inscriptions in an undeciphered script .
  - **Hydraulic engineering:** The Harappans built sophisticated systems of water management, such as wells, reservoirs, canals, drains, and baths. They also had a sanitation system that included flush toilets and covered sewers .
  - **Urban planning:** The Harappans built well-planned cities with grid-like layouts, fortified walls, and standardized bricks. They also had public buildings, such as granaries, warehouses, and citadels. The

cities were divided into two parts: the upper town, which was the administrative and religious center, and the lower town, which was the residential and commercial area.

### **Water Management in Ancient India and India**

- Water management is the planning, development, distribution, and use of water resources for various purposes, such as irrigation, drinking, sanitation, power generation, and ecology.
- Water management in ancient India was influenced by the geographical, climatic, cultural, and religious diversity of the subcontinent.
- Some of the main features of water management in ancient India were:
  - The use of natural and artificial water bodies, such as rivers, lakes, ponds, wells, tanks, canals, and stepwells, for storing and supplying water.
  - The development of hydrologic knowledge and techniques, such as the concept of the water cycle, rainfall measurement, water quality assessment, and water treatment methods.
  - The construction of sophisticated hydraulic structures, such as dams, reservoirs, aqueducts, sluices, and water wheels, for controlling and harnessing water flow.
  - The implementation of water conservation and management practices, such as rainwater harvesting, watershed management, crop rotation, and water sharing systems.
  - The integration of water management with social, economic, and religious aspects of life, such as water rights, water taxes, water festivals, and water worship.
- Some of the examples of water management in ancient India are:
  - The Harappan civilization (c. 3000-1500 BCE), which had a well-planned urban water supply and drainage system, including public and private wells, baths, and latrines .
  - The Vedic period (c. 1500-500 BCE), which had a rich literature on water-related topics, such as the Rigveda, which contains hymns to various water deities, and the Arthashastra, which prescribes rules and regulations for water management.
  - The Mauryan empire (c. 322-185 BCE), which had a centralized administration of water resources, including the appointment of water officers, the collection of water taxes, and the construction of large-scale irrigation works, such as the Sudarshana lake in Gujarat.
  - The Gupta period (c. 320-550 CE), which witnessed the flourishing of science and technology, including the development of water measurement devices, such as the ghatika (water clock) and the jalayantra (rain gauge), and water treatment methods, such as the use of brass

vessels and plants to purify water .

- The medieval period (c. 600-1700 CE), which saw the emergence of various regional kingdoms and cultures, each with their own distinctive styles and innovations in water management, such as the Chola tanks in Tamil Nadu, the Qanat system in Kashmir, the Bawari system in Rajasthan, and the Ahars and Pynes system in Bihar.
- The Mughal period (c. 1526-1857 CE), which introduced new elements and influences in water management, such as the Persian-style gardens, fountains, and canals, the use of water for aesthetic and recreational purposes, and the patronage of water-related arts and crafts.

### **Textile Technology in India and Ancient India**

- Textile technology is the art and science of producing fabrics from natural or synthetic materials, such as cotton, silk, wool, or polyester.
- India has a long and rich history of textile production and use, dating back to prehistoric times. India was one of the first countries to cultivate cotton and weave it into cloth, as well as to dye and print fabrics with various colors and patterns.
- Some of the sources of information on textile technology in ancient India are:
  - Literary sources, such as Vedas, Ramayana, Mahabharata, Arthashastra, and Buddhist and Jain texts, which mention various types of fabrics, garments, and accessories used by different classes and regions of society.
  - Archaeological sources, such as excavations, inscriptions, coins, sculptures, paintings, and terracotta figurines, which provide evidence of the tools, techniques, and trade of textiles in ancient India.
  - Foreign accounts, such as those of Greek, Roman, Chinese, Persian, and Arab travelers and writers, who praised the quality, variety, and beauty of Indian textiles and recorded their export to various parts of the world.
- Some of the features of textile technology in ancient India are:
  - Cotton was the most widely used material for textiles, followed by silk, wool, and linen. Cotton was grown in various regions of India, such as the Indus Valley, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Bengal, and Tamil Nadu. Cotton fibers were spun into yarns using simple devices, such as spindles and wheels, and then woven into fabrics using horizontal or vertical looms.
  - Silk was produced from the cocoons of silkworms, which were reared on mulberry trees. Silk was mainly cultivated in eastern and southern India, especially in Assam, Bengal, and Karnataka. Silk fabrics were highly valued and used for royal and religious purposes, as well as for trade with foreign countries.
  - Wool was obtained from sheep, goats, and camels, and was mainly

used in the colder regions of India, such as Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, and Rajasthan. Woolen fabrics were known for their warmth, softness, and durability, and were used for making shawls, blankets, carpets, and rugs.

- Linen was made from the fibers of the flax plant, which was grown in northern India, especially in Punjab and Uttar Pradesh. Linen fabrics were known for their strength, smoothness, and absorbency, and were used for making garments, towels, and bandages.
- Dyeing and printing were the two main methods of adding colors and patterns to fabrics. Dyeing involved immersing the fabrics or yarns in natural or synthetic dyes, such as indigo, madder, turmeric, saffron, lac, and kermes. Printing involved applying dyes or pigments to the fabrics using blocks, stamps, brushes, or stencils, creating various motifs, such as floral, geometric, animal, or human figures.
- Textiles were also embellished with various techniques, such as embroidery, applique, patchwork, quilting, tie-and-dye, batik, ikat, brocade, and zari. These techniques involved using threads, beads, sequins, shells, coins, or metal wires to create decorative designs on the fabrics, enhancing their aesthetic appeal and value.
- Textiles were an important part of the culture and economy of ancient India. They were used for making various types of garments, such as saris, dhotis, kurtas, cholis, turbans, shawls, and veils, as well as for making household items, such as curtains, cushions, bedspreads, and mats. They were also used for religious and ceremonial purposes, such as offering to gods, wrapping idols, covering shrines, and decorating temples. Textiles were also a major commodity of trade, both within and outside India, and were exchanged for spices, gold, silver, ivory, and other goods. Textiles were a symbol of status, wealth, and identity, and reflected the diversity and creativity of the Indian people.

### **Writing Technology in India and Ancient India**

- Writing technology refers to the tools and methods used to create, preserve, and transmit written texts.
- India has a rich and diverse history of writing technology, spanning from the ancient Indus Valley civilization to the modern digital era.
- Some of the main aspects of writing technology in India and ancient India are:
  - Writing systems: India has developed and used various writing systems, such as the syllabic Kharosthi and semialphabetic Brahmi scripts of ancient India, the Devanagari script of Sanskrit and Hindi, the Perso-Arabic script of Urdu, and the many regional scripts of other languages. India also has a tradition of oral literature, which

is transmitted through memory and performance.

- Writing materials: India has used various materials for writing, such as stone, metal, clay, palm leaves, birch bark, paper, and cloth. Stone was the principal writing material in ancient India, as it was durable and widely available. Metal was used for inscriptions on coins, seals, and plates. Clay was used for making tablets and seals, especially in the Indus Valley civilization. Palm leaves and birch bark were used for making manuscripts, as they were flexible and lightweight. Paper was introduced to India by the Arabs in the 10th century CE, and cloth was used for banners and scrolls.
- Writing instruments: India has used various instruments for writing, such as chisels, punches, styluses, pens, brushes, and keyboards. Chisels and punches were used for carving and engraving on stone and metal. Styluses were used for writing on clay and wax. Pens and brushes were used for writing on paper and cloth, using ink made from plant or animal sources. Keyboards are used for typing on computers and mobile devices, using transliteration software or Indic script keyboards.
- Writing practices: India has developed and followed various writing practices, such as calligraphy, typography, printing, and digitization. Calligraphy is the art of writing beautifully and elegantly, using various styles and scripts. Typography is the design and arrangement of letters and symbols, using various fonts and layouts. Printing is the process of reproducing texts using machines, such as woodblock printing, movable type printing, and lithography. Digitization is the process of converting texts into digital formats, such as PDF, HTML, and XML, using scanners, optical character recognition, and markup languages.

### **Pyrotechnics in India and Ancient India**

- Pyrotechnics is the art and science of creating and using fireworks for entertainment, military, or ceremonial purposes.
- The origin of pyrotechnics is traced back to China, where gunpowder was invented around the 9th century CE and used for fireworks, rockets, and weapons.
- The gunpowder technology and the pyrotechnical entertainment mixtures found their way from China to India through the Arabs. One of the earliest accounts of fireworks in India is made by Abdur Razzaq, the ambassador of the Timurid Sultan Shahrukh to the court of the Vijayanagar king Devaraya II in 1443 .
- Fireworks and pyrotechnic shows existed as a form of royal entertainment in many medieval Indian kingdoms during festivals, events and special occasions like weddings. Manufacturing formulas for fireworks describing pyrotechnic mixtures are found within Kautukachintamani, a Sanskrit volume by Gajapati Prataparudradeva (1497-1539), a reputed king of Odisha

- It is possible that Chinese pyrotechnic formulas were brought to India around 1400 AD and modified according to ingredients that were available in India. There are accounts of fireworks being used in 1518 in weddings in Gujarat, and in 1609 when Ibrahim Adil Shah, the Sultan of Bijapur spent Rs 80,000 on fireworks alone.
- Fireworks became a popular feature of religious and cultural festivals in India, especially Diwali, the festival of lights. Fireworks are also used to celebrate other occasions such as weddings, birthdays, anniversaries, and New Year's Eve.
- India is one of the largest producers and consumers of fireworks in the world, with an estimated annual turnover of Rs 20,000 crore and employing over 8 lakh people, mostly in Tamil Nadu.
- Fireworks have also been a source of environmental and health concerns in India, as they cause air and noise pollution, fire accidents, injuries, and animal distress. Several regulations and bans have been imposed by the government and the courts to limit the use and sale of fireworks, especially during Diwali.
- Pyrotechnics is a fascinating and ancient art that has enriched the cultural and historical heritage of India, but also poses challenges and risks that need to be addressed responsibly and sustainably.

### **Trade in Ancient India**

- Trade in ancient India was an important source of commerce and cultural exchange since the Harappan civilization (c. 2600-1900 BCE) .
- The Harappans traded gold, copper, ivory, beads, textiles, spices, and other goods with Mesopotamia, Egypt, Persia, and Central Asia .
- The decline of the Harappan civilization was followed by the rise of new urban centers such as Pataliputra, Ujjain, Puhar, and Mathura, which became hubs of trade and political power .
- Trade in ancient India involved both inland and maritime routes, connecting the subcontinent with regions such as Southeast Asia, China, Rome, Arabia, and Africa .
- The trade routes were facilitated by the development of roads, ports, coins, weights, measures, and guilds .
- The trade in ancient India was influenced by the political, religious, and economic factors of different periods, such as the Mauryan empire, the Kushan empire, the Satavahana dynasty, the Gupta empire, and the Chola dynasty .
- The trade in ancient India also contributed to the spread of art, literature, science, technology, and religion, such as Buddhism, Hinduism, Jainism, and Islam .

### **India's Dominance up to Pre-colonial Times and Ancient India**

- India is one of the oldest civilizations in the world, with a history that dates back to 2500 BC, when the Indus Valley cities were just starting to grow .
- India was home to a rich cultural and religious diversity, with various empires, kingdoms, and dynasties ruling over different regions and periods of time .
- Some of the most notable empires and dynasties in ancient and medieval India were the Mauryan Empire (321-185 BC), the Gupta Empire (320-550 AD), the Chola Empire (9th-13th century AD), the Delhi Sultanate (1206-1526 AD), and the Mughal Empire (1526-1857 AD) .
- These empires and dynasties contributed to the development of India's art, architecture, literature, science, mathematics, astronomy, medicine, religion, philosophy, law, and administration .
- India also had extensive trade and cultural contacts with other regions of the world, such as Central Asia, West Asia, Southeast Asia, China, Africa, and Europe, through land and sea routes .
- India's dominance and influence in the pre-colonial times was challenged by the arrival of European powers, especially the British, who gradually established their political and economic control over most of India by the 19th century .
- India's struggle for independence from British colonial rule began in the late 19th century and culminated in the partition of India and Pakistan in 1947 .

### **Module 5- Cultural Heritage and Performing Arts**

- Cultural heritage is the legacy of physical and intangible attributes of a group or society that are inherited from past generations, maintained in the present and bestowed for the benefit of future generations.
- Cultural heritage includes tangible culture (such as buildings, monuments, landscapes, books, works of art, and artefacts), intangible culture (such as folklore, traditions, language, and knowledge), and natural heritage (such as culturally significant landscapes, and biodiversity).
- Performing arts are forms of art that use the body, voice, or objects to convey artistic expression, such as music, dance, theatre, opera, mime, puppetry, circus arts, and performance art.
- Performing arts are often performed in front of an audience, but may also be performed for a specific purpose, such as ritual, education, or social change.
- Performing arts are part of the intangible cultural heritage of many cultures and civilizations, as they reflect the creativity, values, identity, and history of the people who practice them.



- Performing arts can also contribute to the preservation and transmission of tangible cultural heritage, such as musical instruments, masks, costumes, props, and scenery.
- Some examples of performing arts that are recognized by UNESCO as intangible cultural heritage are:
  - Urtiin Duu, traditional folk long song of Mongolia, which is sung in a specific vocal technique that requires great skill and endurance.
  - Wayang puppet theatre of Indonesia, which is a form of storytelling that uses flat leather puppets, accompanied by a gamelan orchestra and a narrator.
  - Flamenco of Spain, which is a musical and dance expression that combines singing, guitar playing, hand clapping, finger snapping, and dancing, influenced by various cultures and regions.
  - Kabuki theatre of Japan, which is a classical drama that combines music, dance, and acting, characterized by elaborate costumes, makeup, and stage devices.
  - Tango of Argentina and Uruguay, which is a social dance and musical genre that originated in the late 19th century among the lower classes of Buenos Aires and Montevideo.
- Some of the benefits of performing arts for cultural heritage are:
  - They foster cultural diversity and intercultural dialogue, as they showcase the richness and variety of human expressions and interactions.
  - They promote social cohesion and inclusion, as they create opportunities for participation, communication, and collaboration among different groups and individuals.
  - They enhance individual and collective well-being, as they provide enjoyment, entertainment, education, and emotional and spiritual enrichment.
  - They support sustainable development, as they generate income, employment, and innovation, and contribute to the conservation and management of natural and cultural resources.

: **Source: Khan Academy, What is Cultural Heritage?** Source: UNESCO, Performing arts (such as traditional music, dance and theatre)

### **Indian Architecture in Ancient India and present times**

- Indian architecture is rooted in the history, culture, and religion of India. It reflects the diversity and richness of Indian civilization and has influenced the architecture of other regions as well.
- Indian architecture can be broadly classified into two main categories: Hindu temple architecture and Indo-Islamic architecture. Both of these styles have evolved over time and have various sub-styles and regional

variations.

- Hindu temple architecture is the most prominent and distinctive form of Indian architecture. It is based on the principles of Vastu Shastra, which is a traditional system of architecture that prescribes the layout, design, and construction of buildings in harmony with the natural and cosmic forces.
- Hindu temple architecture can be divided into three main types: Nagara, Dravida, and Vesara. Nagara temples are characterized by a curvilinear tower (shikhara) over the sanctum (garbhagriha), a pillared hall (mandapa), and an entrance porch (ardhamandapa). Dravida temples have a pyramidal tower (vimana) over the sanctum, a pillared hall, and a gateway tower (gopuram). Vesara temples are a hybrid of Nagara and Dravida styles, with features of both.
- Some of the famous examples of Hindu temple architecture are the Kailasa temple at Ellora, the Khajuraho temples, the Brihadeeswarar temple at Thanjavur, the Meenakshi temple at Madurai, the Sun temple at Konark, and the Somnath temple at Gujarat.
- Indo-Islamic architecture is the result of the fusion of Islamic and Indian architectural elements. It emerged after the arrival of Muslim invaders and rulers in India, who brought with them their own styles and techniques of building. Indo-Islamic architecture can be divided into two main types: Sultanate architecture and Mughal architecture.
- Sultanate architecture is the style of architecture that developed under the Delhi Sultanate and other regional Muslim kingdoms in India from the 12th to the 16th century. It is characterized by the use of arches, domes, minarets, and decorative motifs such as calligraphy, geometric patterns, and floral designs. Sultanate architecture also incorporated elements of Hindu and Jain architecture, such as pillars, brackets, and carvings.
- Some of the famous examples of Sultanate architecture are the Qutub Minar, the Alai Darwaza, the Tughlaqabad fort, the Adhai Din Ka Jhonpra, the Gol Gumbaz, and the Charminar.
- Mughal architecture is the style of architecture that developed under the Mughal Empire from the 16th to the 18th century. It is considered to be the most refined and sophisticated form of Indo-Islamic architecture. It is characterized by the use of white marble, red sandstone, inlay work, pietra dura, cusped arches, bulbous domes, chhatris, and gardens.
- Some of the famous examples of Mughal architecture are the Taj Mahal, the Red Fort, the Humayun's Tomb, the Jama Masjid, the Fatehpur Sikri, and the Shalimar Gardens.
- Indian architecture in present times is a blend of traditional and modern styles, influenced by various factors such as globalization, urbanization, technology, and sustainability. Indian architecture today reflects the diversity and dynamism of the contemporary Indian society and culture.
- Some of the famous examples of Indian architecture in present times are the Lotus Temple, the Akshardham Temple, the Chandigarh Capitol Complex, the Bahá'í House of Worship, the Infosys Building, and the Antilia.

## **Engineering and Architecture as Cultural Heritage of India**

- India has a rich and diverse architectural heritage that reflects its history, culture, and religion.
- India's architectural styles and traditions can be classified into several categories, such as Hindu temple architecture, Indo-Islamic architecture, South Indian architecture, Indo-Saracenic architecture, and colonial architecture.
- Some of the engineering marvels in Indian architecture include the Taj Mahal, the Qutub Minar, the Brihadeeswarar Temple, the Konark Sun Temple, the Hampi ruins, the Khajuraho temples, the Ajanta and Ellora caves, the Sanchi Stupa, the Jantar Mantar, and the Lepakshi Temple.
- These structures demonstrate the mastery of various engineering techniques, such as stone carving, dome construction, arch and vault design, water management, acoustics, and astronomy.
- India's architecture also depicts its multicultural heritage, as it shows the influence of various cultures and religions, such as Buddhism, Jainism, Islam, Christianity, Sikhism, and Zoroastrianism.
- India's architecture also reflects its regional diversity, as different regions have developed their own distinctive styles and features, such as the Dravidian style of South India, the Nagara style of North India, the Kalinga style of Odisha, the Hoysala style of Karnataka, the Chola style of Tamil Nadu, and the Maratha style of Maharashtra.
- India's architectural heritage is a valuable source of cultural identity, pride, and inspiration for the nation. It also attracts millions of tourists and scholars from around the world.
- India's architectural heritage faces several challenges and threats, such as urbanization, pollution, vandalism, natural disasters, and lack of awareness and conservation.
- India needs to adopt new paradigms and strategies for preserving and promoting its architectural heritage, such as involving local communities, integrating heritage with development, using digital technologies, and fostering international cooperation.

## **Sculptures as Cultural Heritage of India**

- Sculpture is one of the oldest and most diverse forms of artistic expression in India, dating back to the Indus Valley Civilization (c. 2500-1500 BCE) and continuing to the present day .
- Sculpture in India reflects the rich cultural, religious, and philosophical diversity of the subcontinent, as well as the influences of various regions, dynasties, and foreign invaders .
- Sculpture in India can be classified into three broad categories: stone, metal, and terracotta. Each category has its own distinctive features, techniques, and styles.

- Stone sculpture is the most prevalent and enduring form of sculpture in India, especially in temples, caves, and monuments. Stone sculpture ranges from the naturalistic and realistic to the abstract and symbolic, and often depicts deities, mythical creatures, humans, animals, and floral motifs .
- Metal sculpture is another important form of sculpture in India, especially in bronze and iron. Metal sculpture is known for its intricate craftsmanship, fluidity, and dynamism, and often depicts gods and goddesses, especially in the Chola period (c. 9th-13th century CE) . Metal sculpture also includes coins, weapons, utensils, and ornaments.
- Terracotta sculpture is the oldest and most widespread form of sculpture in India, especially in rural areas. Terracotta sculpture is made from clay and baked in fire, and often depicts animals, birds, humans, and toys. Terracotta sculpture also includes pottery, figurines, and masks .
- Some of the famous examples of sculpture in India are:
  - The Dancing Girl, Mohenjo-daro, c. 2500 BCE: A bronze figurine of a young girl in a dancing pose, considered to be one of the earliest representations of human movement and expression in art.
  - Ashoka Pillar, Sarnath, 3rd century BCE: A stone pillar with a four-lion capital, representing the emblem of the Mauryan Empire and the symbol of Buddhism.
  - Buddha statues, various locations, 3rd century BCE onwards: Stone and metal statues of the founder of Buddhism, depicting his various postures, gestures, and expressions, such as the Dharmachakra Mudra (teaching gesture), the Abhaya Mudra (fearlessness gesture), and the Mahaparinirvana (death) pose .
  - Khajuraho temples, Madhya Pradesh, 10th-12th century CE: A group of stone temples with erotic sculptures, representing the Tantric philosophy of union and liberation .
  - Nataraja, Chola period, 11th-12th century CE: A bronze statue of Shiva as the lord of dance, depicting his cosmic dance of creation and destruction, with his four arms, drum, fire, and ring of flames .
  - Konark Sun Temple, Odisha, 13th century CE: A stone temple dedicated to the sun god Surya, with elaborate carvings of animals, humans, and celestial bodies .
  - Taj Mahal, Agra, 17th century CE: A marble mausoleum built by the Mughal emperor Shah Jahan for his wife Mumtaz Mahal, with intricate inlay work, calligraphy, and floral motifs .
- Sculpture in India is a valuable cultural heritage that showcases the artistic genius, aesthetic sensibility, and spiritual vision of the Indian people. Sculpture in India also reflects the historical, social, and political changes that have shaped the subcontinent over the centuries. Sculpture in India is a source of inspiration, education, and enjoyment for the present and future generations.

### Seals as Cultural Heritage of India

- Seals are small objects made of stone, metal, or other materials that have a carved or engraved design on one side and are used to stamp or seal documents, goods, or containers.
- Seals have been used in India since ancient times, especially by the Indus Valley Civilization (2500-1900 BCE), one of the earliest urban civilizations in the world.
- The Indus seals are mostly made of steatite, a soft stone that can be easily carved, and are usually square or rectangular in shape, with a perforated knob on the back for holding or attaching a cord.
- The Indus seals have various designs on the front, such as animals, humans, mythical creatures, geometric patterns, or symbols. Some of the common animals depicted are elephants, tigers, water buffaloes, rhinoceroses, and unicorns. Some of the human figures are shown in a seated posture, wearing a horned headdress, and are interpreted as deities or rulers.
- The Indus seals also have a script on the front, which is still undeciphered. The script consists of about 400 signs, some of which are pictographic and some of which are abstract. The script is written from right to left, and may represent a language or a system of symbols.
- The Indus seals were used for various purposes, such as identifying property, marking trade goods, sealing containers, or expressing religious beliefs. The seals have been found in many sites of the Indus Valley Civilization, as well as in other regions, such as Mesopotamia, Afghanistan, Iran, and Bahrain, indicating the extensive trade and cultural contacts of the Indus people.
- The Indus seals are valuable sources of information about the Indus Valley Civilization, its culture, economy, religion, and society. They also reflect the artistic and technological achievements of the Indus people, who were skilled in carving, engraving, and firing steatite. The seals are considered as cultural heritage of India, as they represent one of the oldest and most sophisticated civilizations of the ancient world.

### Coins as Cultural Heritage of India

- Coins are one of the most important sources of information about the history, culture, religion, economy, and politics of ancient and medieval India .
- Coins reflect the artistic skills, technological innovations, political aspirations, and religious beliefs of the people who issued and used them .
- Coins also provide evidence of trade, commerce, urbanization, and cultural interactions among different regions and civilizations .
- The origin of coinage in India can be traced back to the first millennium BCE, when punch-marked coins made of copper and silver were used as a medium of exchange .
- The earliest coins were called karshapanas or panas, and they had symbols

or marks punched on them to indicate their value and authenticity .

- The coins of the Mauryan Empire (4th-2nd century BCE) were the first to have inscriptions in Brahmi script and Prakrit language, as well as images of animals, plants, and geometric patterns .
- The coins of the Indo-Greek, Indo-Scythian, and Indo-Parthian kingdoms (2nd century BCE-2nd century CE) introduced the use of Greek script and legends, as well as portraits of kings and deities .
- The coins of the Kushan Empire (1st-3rd century CE) were the first to depict the Buddha and other Indian and Iranian gods, as well as the first to use gold as a metal for coinage .
- The coins of the Gupta Empire (4th-6th century CE) were the most artistic and sophisticated in ancient India, with realistic portraits of kings, elaborate legends in Sanskrit, and symbols of Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism .
- The coins of the medieval period (7th-16th century CE) witnessed the emergence of new dynasties, religions, and languages, such as the Chalukyas, Pallavas, Rashtrakutas, Cholas, Pandyas, Delhi Sultanate, Vijayanagara Empire, Bahmani Sultanate, Mughal Empire, and Maratha Empire .
- The coins of this period were made of various metals, such as gold, silver, copper, bronze, lead, and tin, and had inscriptions in different scripts and languages, such as Brahmi, Nagari, Kannada, Tamil, Telugu, Arabic, Persian, and Urdu .
- The coins of this period also displayed diverse motifs, such as lions, horses, elephants, bulls, peacocks, lotuses, suns, moons, stars, crescents, crosses, tridents, swastikas, om, and kalash .
- The coins of India are a rich and valuable cultural heritage that reveal the diversity and dynamism of the Indian civilization over the centuries .

### **Pottery as Cultural Heritage of India**

- Pottery is one of the most ancient and enduring forms of artistic expression in India. It reflects the diversity and richness of Indian culture and history.
- Pottery in India dates back to the prehistoric times, as evidenced by the findings of pottery shards in the early settlements of Lahuradewa and Mehargarh .
- The Indus Valley Civilization (2600-1900 BCE) was one of the first cultures to produce sophisticated pottery, with various shapes, sizes, colors and designs. The pottery of this civilization was mainly wheel-made and fired in kilns .
- Pottery in India continued to evolve and flourish in different regions and periods, such as the Mauryan, Kushan, Gupta, Harappan, Chalcolithic, Iron Age and Medieval periods. Each period had its own distinctive style and technique of pottery making, influenced by the local environment, materials, traditions and beliefs .
- Pottery in India is not only a functional craft, but also a form of art and

culture. Pottery is used for various purposes, such as cooking, storing, serving, decorating, worshipping and gifting. Pottery also reflects the social, religious and aesthetic values of the people who make and use it .

- Pottery in India is still a living and vibrant craft tradition, practiced by many communities and individuals across the country. Pottery is also a source of livelihood and identity for many potters, who inherit and pass on their skills and knowledge to the next generations .
- Pottery in India is a cultural heritage that deserves to be preserved and promoted, as it showcases the creativity, diversity and continuity of Indian civilization. Pottery is also an eco-friendly and sustainable craft, as it uses natural and biodegradable materials and does not cause pollution or waste.

### **Puppetry as Cultural Heritage of India**

- Puppetry is one of the most imaginative and ancient ways of telling a story in the society.
- Puppetry has been in India a means of entertainment and a form of cultural and religious dissemination.
- Several regions in India have their own distinct styles and genres of puppetry, making it one of the richest heritages of the country.
- The origin of puppetry in India cannot be dated, but mythology provides at least two stories that are witness to the importance of this art.
- One story is from the Mahabharata, where Arjuna creates a puppet of his son Abhimanyu and performs his funeral rites with it.
- Another story is from the Ramayana, where Ravana uses a puppet of Sita to deceive Rama and Lakshmana.
- There are four main types of puppetry in India: string puppets, rod puppets, glove puppets and shadow puppets.
- String puppets are controlled by strings attached to different parts of the puppet's body. They are also known as marionettes. The most popular and predominant form of string puppetry in India is Kathputli, which is native to Rajasthan .
- Rod puppets are manipulated by rods attached to the puppet's limbs or head. They are usually larger and more expressive than string puppets. The most famous form of rod puppetry in India is Putul Nautch, which is practiced in West Bengal.
- Glove puppets are worn on the hand of the puppeteer, who moves the fingers to animate the puppet's mouth and arms. They are also called hand puppets. The most well-known form of glove puppetry in India is Pavakoothu, which is performed in Kerala.
- Shadow puppets are flat cut-out figures that are held against a translucent screen and illuminated from behind. They create silhouettes and shadows on the screen. The most renowned form of shadow puppetry in India is Tholu Bommalata, which is prevalent in Andhra Pradesh.
- Puppetry in India is not only a form of art, but also a medium of education, social awareness and cultural preservation.

- Puppetry in India reflects the diversity, creativity and richness of the Indian culture and heritage.

### **Dance as Cultural Heritage of India**

- Dance is an ancient and celebrated cultural tradition in India that reflects the diversity, history and beliefs of its people.
- Dance in India can be classified into two main categories: classical and folk.
- Classical dance forms are based on the ancient texts of Natya Shastra and Abhinaya Darpana, and have a codified set of rules, techniques and gestures.
- Classical dance forms are usually performed in temples, courts and theatres, and are accompanied by classical music, costumes and makeup.
- The Sangeet Natak Academy recognises eight classical dance forms in India, namely, Bharatnatyam, Kathak, Kuchipudi, Kathakali, Odissi, Mohiniyattam, Manipuri and Satriya.
- Each classical dance form has its own regional origin, style, theme and expression, and showcases the rich heritage and cultural diversity of India.
- Folk dance forms are more spontaneous, informal and flexible, and are performed by the common people during festivals, weddings and other occasions.
- Folk dance forms are influenced by the local geography, climate, culture and traditions, and often incorporate elements of storytelling, humour and social commentary.
- Every part of India has its unique folk dance, such as Bhangra, Garba, Lavani, Bihu, Chhau, Ghoomar, Dandiya and many more.
- Folk dance forms are a living and evolving expression of the collective identity and aspirations of the people, and contribute to the vibrant and colourful mosaic of Indian culture.

### **Music as Cultural Heritage of India**

- Music is an integral part of the cultural heritage of India, reflecting its diversity, history and evolution over the centuries.
- Music of India can be broadly classified into two main traditions: Indian classical music and Indian folk music.
- Indian classical music is based on the concepts of raga (melodic framework) and tala (rhythmic framework). It has two major branches: Carnatic music, which is prevalent in South India, and Hindustani music, which is prevalent in North India.
- Indian classical music has its origins in the ancient Hindu scriptures, the Vedas, and has been influenced by various religious and cultural movements, such as Buddhism, Islam, Sikhism, and the Bhakti movement.
- Indian classical music is performed by soloists or ensembles, using vocal or instrumental techniques. Some of the prominent instruments used in



Indian classical music are the sitar, the sarod, the tabla, the harmonium, the veena, the flute, and the violin.

- Indian folk music is a diverse and vibrant genre of music that reflects the regional, linguistic, and ethnic diversity of India. It is often associated with festivals, rituals, celebrations, and social occasions.
- Indian folk music encompasses a wide range of styles, such as bhangra, lavani, dandiya, baul, qawwali, bhajan, and ghazal. Some of the popular instruments used in Indian folk music are the dhol, the dholak, the ektara, the sarangi, the bansuri, and the harmonica.
- Indian music has also been influenced by and has influenced various genres of world music, such as pop, rock, jazz, and fusion. Some of the notable Indian musicians who have contributed to the global music scene are Ravi Shankar, Zakir Hussain, A.R. Rahman, Lata Mangeshkar, Asha Bhosle, and Kishore Kumar.

### **Theatre as Cultural Heritage of India**

- Theatre is a form of art that combines music, dance, dialogue, and spectacle to create a live performance that entertains and educates the audience.
- Theatre in India has a long and rich history that dates back to the Vedic period, when religious rituals and hymns were performed as a form of worship and communication with the gods.
- The earliest text on theatre in India is the Natya Shastra, written by Bharata Muni around 500 BC. It is a comprehensive treatise that covers various aspects of theatre, such as aesthetics, dramaturgy, stagecraft, music, dance, and acting .
- Theatre in India has evolved through three main periods: the classical period, the traditional period, and the modern period.
  - The classical period (from 500 BC to 1000 AD) was marked by the development of Sanskrit drama, which followed the rules and conventions of the Natya Shastra. The most famous playwrights of this period were Kalidasa, Bhasa, Shudraka, and Vishakhadatta. Their plays were based on epics, legends, history, and social issues, and were performed in royal courts and temples.
  - The traditional period (from 1000 AD to 1800 AD) was characterized by the emergence and growth of various regional forms of theatre, such as Kutiyattam, Kathakali, Yakshagana, Bhavai, Nautanki, Tamasha, Jatra, and Ramlila. These forms were influenced by local cultures, languages, religions, and folk traditions, and were performed in rural and urban settings for the masses. They used music, dance, masks, costumes, and props to create colorful and lively spectacles .
  - The modern period (from 1800 AD to present) was initiated by the introduction of Western theatre and influences, such as realism, naturalism, social drama, and experimental theatre. The colonial rule, the nationalist movement, the independence struggle, and the post-independence issues shaped the themes and styles of modern Indian

theatre. Some of the prominent playwrights and directors of this period are Rabindranath Tagore, Mohan Rakesh, Vijay Tendulkar, Girish Karnad, Badal Sircar, Habib Tanvir, and Satyadev Dubey .

- Theatre in India is a cultural heritage that reflects the diversity, creativity, and identity of the Indian people. It is a medium of expression, education, and entertainment that has survived and adapted to the changing times and contexts. It is a living tradition that continues to evolve and innovate, and to contribute to the global theatre scene .

### **Drama as Cultural Heritage of India**

- Drama is a form of performing arts, where stories are enacted by the utilisation of dialogue, music, gesture, dance, and sound.
- Drama is one of the oldest and most diverse forms of cultural expression in India, dating back to the ancient Vedic period .
- Drama in India has been influenced by various religious, social, and linguistic traditions, as well as by regional and historical factors .
- Drama in India can be broadly classified into two categories: classical and folk.
- Classical drama in India is based on the Sanskrit theatre, which is the earliest existing form of drama and theatre in the world . Sanskrit theatre was codified by Bharata Muni in his treatise *Natyashastra*, which is considered the fifth Veda by Hindus. Sanskrit theatre follows the principles of *rasa* (aesthetic emotion), *dhvani* (suggestion), *alamkara* (ornamentation), and *abhinaya* (acting). Some of the famous Sanskrit playwrights are Kalidasa, Bhasa, Sudraka, Vishakhadatta, and Harsha .
- Folk drama in India is a diverse and vibrant form of theatre, which reflects the local cultures, languages, and traditions of various regions and communities in India. Folk drama is usually performed in open-air venues, such as village squares, courtyards, or temples, and involves the participation of the audience. Folk drama incorporates elements of music, dance, mime, puppetry, masks, and costumes, and often deals with themes of social satire, myth, legend, and history. Some of the popular forms of folk drama in India are Nautanki, Tamasha, Jatra, Bhavai, Yakshagana, and Therukoothu.
- Drama in India has also been influenced by the colonial and post-colonial periods, which introduced new genres, styles, and themes to the Indian theatre scene. Some of the notable modern Indian playwrights are Rabindranath Tagore, Mohan Rakesh, Vijay Tendulkar, Girish Karnad, Badal Sircar, and Mahesh Dattani.
- Drama in India is a rich and diverse cultural heritage, which showcases the creativity, diversity, and dynamism of the Indian people and their history. Drama in India is also a medium of social commentary, cultural critique, and artistic expression, which reflects the contemporary issues and challenges faced by the Indian society .

## Painting as Cultural Heritage of India

- Painting is one of the oldest and most diverse forms of art in India, dating back to prehistoric times.
- Painting reflects the cultural, religious, and political aspects of Indian society, as well as the aesthetic and creative expressions of the artists.
- Painting in India can be classified into various styles, such as mural, miniature, folk, tribal, modern, and contemporary, each with its own characteristics and influences.
- Some of the most famous and distinctive types of Indian paintings are:
  - Madhubani: A folk painting style from Bihar, characterized by bright colors, geometric patterns, and symbolic motifs depicting gods, goddesses, animals, plants, and scenes from mythology and daily life. Madhubani paintings are usually done on walls, floors, or paper using natural dyes and brushes made from bamboo or cotton.
  - Warli: A tribal painting style from Maharashtra, characterized by simple and monochromatic hues, linear figures, and an elementary style of execution that resembles cave painting. Warli paintings depict the social and cultural life of the Warli tribe, such as farming, hunting, dancing, and rituals. Warli paintings are usually done on mud walls using rice paste or white paint .
  - Mughal: A miniature painting style that flourished under the Mughal dynasty from the 16th to the 19th century, influenced by Persian, Indian, and European art. Mughal paintings are known for their realism, rich colors, intricate details, and delicate brushwork. Mughal paintings depict scenes from history, literature, court life, nature, and portraits of rulers and nobles. Mughal paintings are usually done on paper, silk, or ivory using watercolors, gold, and silver .
  - Rajasthani: A miniature painting style that originated in Rajasthan, influenced by Mughal, Persian, and local art. Rajasthani paintings are known for their vibrant colors, elaborate costumes, expressive faces, and romantic themes. Rajasthani paintings depict scenes from Hindu epics, legends, folklore, and court life. Rajasthani paintings are usually done on paper, cloth, or wood using watercolors, gold, and silver .
  - Tanjore: A classical painting style from Tamil Nadu, influenced by Hindu and South Indian art. Tanjore paintings are known for their rich colors, gold foils, precious stones, and relief work. Tanjore paintings depict gods, goddesses, saints, and scenes from Hindu scriptures. Tanjore paintings are usually done on wood, cloth, or paper using watercolors, gold, and silver .
- Painting in India is a living and evolving art form that continues to adapt to changing times and tastes, while preserving its unique identity and

heritage. Painting in India is a source of pride, inspiration, and joy for the people of India and the world.

### **Martial Arts Traditions of India**

- Martial arts are codified systems and traditions of combat practices, which are practised for a variety of reasons – self-defence, competition, physical health and fitness, entertainment, as well as mental, physical, and spiritual development.
- India has an ancient tradition in diverse martial arts, dating back to the Vedic period and influenced by the geography, culture, and history of the subcontinent.
- Some of the most famous martial arts in India are :
  - Kalaripayattu: Often known as the ‘Mother Of All Martial Arts’, this 3000-year old art form originating from Kerala, draws inspiration from the raw power, swift movements and sinuous strength of majestic animals – the lion, tiger, elephant, wild boar, snake and crocodile. It involves strikes, kicks, grappling, weaponry, and healing methods.
  - Silambam: A weapon-based martial art from Tamil Nadu, Silambam uses a bamboo staff as the primary weapon, along with other secondary weapons such as swords, daggers, and spears. It is known for its fast and fluid movements, and its use of circular patterns and footwork.
  - Gatka: A Sikh martial art that originated in Punjab, Gatka is mainly focused on the use of swords, sticks, and shields. It is also a sport that involves sparring with wooden sticks and protective gear. Gatka is based on the principles of spirituality, discipline, and service.
  - Thang-Ta: The ancient Manipuri martial art, also known as Huyen Lallong, Thang-Ta involves the use of swords and spears, as well as unarmed combat. It is a powerful yet gracefully complex technique that reflects the culture and history of Manipur.
  - Lathi: Lathi is India’s oldest armed martial art, and also regarded as one of the world’s earliest martial arts weapons. It involves the use of a long bamboo stick, often tipped with metal, to strike, block, and defend. Lathi is widely practised in rural areas of India, especially in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh.
  - Kushti: Kushti is one of the most popular martial arts in India, and also known as traditional wrestling. It started off during the Mughal times, where Malla Yuddha, a local sport, was combined with a Persian sport named Varzesh-e-Bastani. Kushti involves grappling, takedowns, locks, and holds, and is practised on a clay or dirt pit.
  - Mardani Khel: Mardani Khel is a martial art from Maharashtra, that was developed by the Maratha warriors in the 17th century. It involves the use of various weapons, such as swords, daggers, axes, spears, and whips, as well as unarmed combat. Mardani Khel is

known for its agility, strength, and courage.

- **Sqay:** Sqay is a martial art from Kashmir, that is influenced by Central Asian and Persian styles. It involves the use of swords, shields, and daggers, as well as kicks, punches, and blocks. Sqay is also a sport that has rules and regulations, and is recognised by the Indian Olympic Association.

### Fairs and Festivals as Cultural Heritage of India

- India is a land of diverse cultures, religions, languages, and traditions. It is also a land of vibrant celebrations, where various fairs and festivals are held throughout the year to mark important occasions, honor deities, commemorate saints, express gratitude, and showcase the rich and colorful heritage of the country .
- Fairs and festivals in India reflect the diversity and unity of the people, as well as the values and beliefs of the society. They also provide an opportunity for people to interact, exchange, and enjoy with each other, as well as to showcase their arts, crafts, cuisines, and lifestyles .
- Some of the most famous fairs and festivals in India are:
  - **Makar Sankranti:** This is a harvest festival celebrated in January, when the sun enters the zodiac sign of Capricorn. It is also known as Pongal, Lohri, Bihu, and Maghi in different regions. It is a time to thank the sun god for the bountiful crops, and to fly kites, light bonfires, and share sweets .
  - **Holi:** This is the festival of colors, celebrated in March, to mark the arrival of spring and the victory of good over evil. It is a time to play with colors, water, and flowers, and to enjoy music, dance, and delicacies. It is also a time to forgive and forget, and to spread joy and love.
  - **Diwali:** This is the festival of lights, celebrated in October or November, to mark the return of Lord Rama from exile and the triumph of light over darkness. It is a time to decorate homes and streets with lamps, candles, and rangoli, and to worship Goddess Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth and prosperity. It is also a time to exchange gifts, sweets, and greetings, and to burst crackers.
  - **Dussehra:** This is the festival of victory, celebrated in September or October, to commemorate the defeat of the demon king Ravana by Lord Rama. It is a time to watch the dramatic reenactment of the epic Ramayana, and to burn the effigies of Ravana, Kumbhakarna, and Meghnad. It is also a time to worship Goddess Durga, the goddess of power and courage.
  - **Ganesh Chaturthi:** This is the festival of the elephant-headed god, celebrated in August or September, to mark his birthday. It is a time to install and worship the idols of Lord Ganesh, the god of wisdom

and success, and to immerse them in water after a few days. It is also a time to enjoy modak, a sweet dumpling, and to chant “Ganpati Bappa Morya”.

- **Pushkar Mela:** This is the largest camel fair in the world, held in November, in the holy town of Pushkar in Rajasthan. It is a time to witness the trading and racing of thousands of camels, horses, and cattle, and to enjoy the cultural and musical performances, competitions, and exhibitions. It is also a time to take a dip in the sacred Pushkar lake, and to visit the only temple of Lord Brahma in India .
- **Jaisalmer Desert Festival:** This is a three-day extravaganza of culture, art, and adventure, held in February, in the golden city of Jaisalmer in Rajasthan. It is a time to experience the desert life, and to enjoy the camel rides, polo, and safaris, as well as the folk dances, music, and puppet shows. It is also a time to witness the contests of turban tying, moustache growing, and Mr. Desert .
- **Goa Carnival:** This is a four-day celebration of fun, frolic, and festivity, held in February or March, in the coastal state of Goa. It is a time to join the colorful parades, floats, and masks, and to enjoy the live bands, dances, and parties. It is also a time to relish the Goan cuisine, especially the seafood, and to indulge in the spirit of “Khush Hali” or happiness .

- These are just some

### Current developments in Arts and Culture in India

- India is a diverse country with a rich and varied cultural heritage. India has one of the world’s largest collections of songs, music, dance, theatre, folk traditions, performing arts, rites and rituals, paintings and writings that are known, as the ‘Intangible Cultural Heritage’ (ICH) of humanity.
- India has also contributed significantly to the global art scene with its ancient and modern forms of art, such as sculpture, architecture, painting, literature, cinema, and more. India has 37 world heritage sites, two thriving film industries and many smaller ones as well.
- In recent years, India has witnessed some new trends and developments in its arts and culture sector, such as:
  - The emergence of contemporary Indian art, which explores new themes, mediums, and styles, influenced by both the local and the global contexts. Contemporary Indian artists have gained recognition and appreciation both nationally and internationally for their innovative and diverse works.
  - The inclusion of three Indian cities, Thrissur and Nilambur in Kerala and Warangal in Telangana, in the UNESCO Global Network of Learning Cities, which aims to promote lifelong learning and sustainable development through education, culture, and social inclusion.
  - The nomination of Hoysala Temples, a group of 13th-century temples

in Karnataka, for inscription in the World Heritage List, for their outstanding artistic and architectural value and their representation of the Hoysala style of temple building.

- The repatriation of a 10th-century Goat-Headed Yogini Statue, which was stolen from a temple in Uttar Pradesh and smuggled to France, after a legal battle of 24 years. The statue is a rare example of the Tantric cult of Yoginis, which worshipped female deities associated with power and fertility.
- The celebration of the Republic Day Parade 2022, which showcased the cultural diversity and unity of India, with various tableaux, cultural performances, and military displays. The parade also featured some new elements, such as the first-ever contingent of women fighter pilots, the first-ever tableau of Ladakh, and the first-ever flypast of the indigenously developed Light Combat Helicopter.
- The launch of ‘Dharohar’, the National Museum of Customs and GST, which showcases the history and evolution of the customs and taxation system in India, from the ancient to the modern times. The museum also displays various artefacts, documents, uniforms, and stamps related to the customs and GST department.
- The publication of ‘Devayatanam’, a book that explores the odyssey of Indian temple architecture, from the prehistoric to the contemporary times. The book covers various aspects of temple building, such as the symbolism, the aesthetics, the engineering, and the rituals, and also highlights the diversity and continuity of the Indian temple tradition.

These are some of the current developments in arts and culture in India, which reflect the dynamism, creativity, and resilience of the Indian people and their culture.

### **Indian’s Cultural Contribution to the World**

India is a country of diverse and rich culture, with a long and ancient history. India has made many contributions to the world in various fields, such as mathematics, architecture, textiles, medicine, language, art, and religion. Some of the most notable contributions are:

- **Mathematics:** India is the birthplace of the concept of zero, the decimal system, and the place-value system. India also developed algebra, trigonometry, geometry, calculus, and astronomy. Some of the famous Indian mathematicians are Aryabhata, Brahmagupta, Bhaskara, and Ramanujan .
- **Architecture:** India has a unique and diverse architectural heritage, influenced by various cultures and religions. India is known for its temples, palaces, forts, monuments, and urban planning. Some of the examples of Indian architecture are the Taj Mahal, the Khajuraho temples, the Qutub Minar, the Hampi ruins, and the Harappan civilization .

- Textiles: India is one of the largest producers and exporters of cotton, silk, and other fabrics in the world. India is also the origin of many techniques and styles of weaving, dyeing, printing, and embroidering. India is famous for its sarees, kurtas, shawls, carpets, and bedspreads. India also invented the spinning wheel, the charkha, and the muslin cloth .
- Medicine: India has a rich tradition of medicine, dating back to the ancient times. India developed the system of Ayurveda, which is based on the balance of the body, mind, and spirit. India also pioneered the fields of surgery, dentistry, plastic surgery, and pharmacology. Some of the notable Indian physicians are Charaka, Sushruta, Nagarjuna, and Vagbhata .
- Language: India is a multilingual country, with 22 official languages and hundreds of regional languages and dialects. India is also the source of many languages and scripts that are spoken and written in other parts of the world, such as Sanskrit, Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, Tamil, and Devanagari. India also influenced the development of English, Persian, Arabic, and other languages through trade, migration, and colonization .
- Art: India has a vibrant and diverse artistic culture, spanning various forms and genres. India is known for its painting, sculpture, literature, music, dance, and theatre. India has produced many masterpieces and legends in the field of art, such as the Ajanta and Ellora caves, the Ramayana and Mahabharata epics, the Carnatic and Hindustani music, the Bharatanatyam and Kathak dance, and the Rabindranath Tagore and Raja Ravi Varma .
- Religion: India is the birthplace of four major religions: Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism. India is also home to many other faiths, such as Islam, Christianity, Judaism, Zoroastrianism, and Baha'i. India has contributed to the world's spiritual and philosophical thought, through concepts such as karma, dharma, yoga, meditation, reincarnation, and non-violence. India has also spread its religious influence to other regions, such as Southeast Asia, China, Japan, and Tibet .

These are some of the major contributions of India to the world, but there are many more. India is a country of diversity, creativity, and innovation, and has enriched the world with its culture.

### **Indian Cinema as a Performing Art in India**

- Indian cinema is a form of artistic expression that combines storytelling, performing arts, and science to create audio-visual narratives that reflect the socio-cultural and political realities of India.
- Indian cinema has a history of more than a century, starting with the silent era in the early 1900s and evolving into the diverse and vibrant industry that it is today, producing films in various languages, genres, and styles.
- Indian cinema is influenced by various forms of Indian performing arts, such as theater, dance, music, and folk arts, that have their roots in the ancient traditions of India, such as the Natyashastra, a treatise on drama



and aesthetics written by Bharata Muni around 200 BC.

- The Natyashastra is considered the foundational text of Indian performing arts, as it lays down the principles of drama, dance, music, and poetry, and introduces the concept of rasa, or the aesthetic emotion, that is the essence of any artistic expression. The Natyashastra identifies nine rasas: shringara (love), hasya (humor), karuna (compassion), raudra (anger), vira (heroism), bhayanaka (fear), bibhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder), and shanta (peace).
- Indian cinema has adopted and adapted the rasa theory to create films that evoke various emotions in the audience, and to explore the themes of love, social justice, nationalism, identity, morality, and spirituality, among others.
- Indian cinema has also been influenced by the Indian People's Theatre Association (IPTA), a cultural and political movement that emerged in the 1940s as a response to the colonial oppression and the freedom struggle. IPTA aimed to use theater and other performing arts as a medium of social change and awareness, and to promote the values of secularism, democracy, and socialism. IPTA produced plays and films that highlighted the issues of the oppressed classes, such as the peasants, the workers, the women, and the minorities, and challenged the feudal, communal, and imperialist forces.
- Indian cinema has also been influenced by the global trends and movements in cinema, such as realism, expressionism, surrealism, neorealism, new wave, and postmodernism, and has experimented with various techniques, styles, and genres, such as documentary, animation, musical, thriller, comedy, horror, and fantasy, to create films that appeal to a wide range of audiences, both domestic and international.
- Indian cinema, as a performing art, has contributed to the cultural and artistic heritage of India, and has also been a source of entertainment, education, and inspiration for millions of people. Indian cinema has also been a platform for showcasing the talents and skills of various artists, such as actors, directors, writers, composers, singers, dancers, cinematographers, editors, and designers, who have enriched the field of cinema with their creativity and innovation.